Autumn 2017

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15

years of

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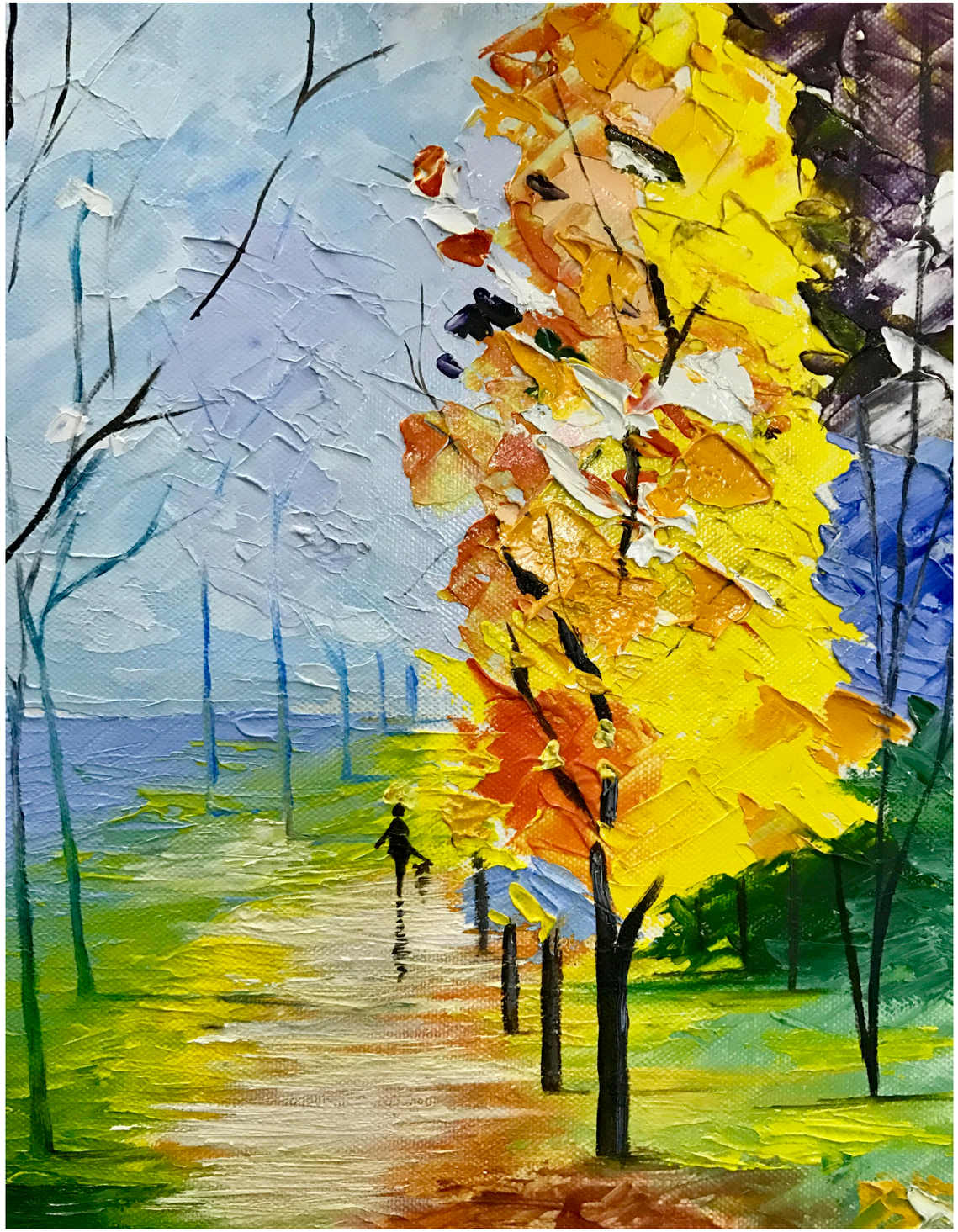
Autumn

Anandadeep Mandal



Cover art by Mithi Chakravarty

Mithi, 27, is a Kolkata-based hearing impaired artist. She has an M.Sc in human development and a diploma in IT application.

Cover art courtesy Anwesha Kolkata, an NGO that works with the disabled.

OUR SINCERE THANKS TO:

Nabakumar Basu, novelist

Ganesh Haloi, artist

Corrigendum

We regret the following errors in the print edition. They have been corrected in this online edition:

1. The credit for the Durga Puja photo accompanying the article "Protima-puja in Hinduism" should read Sovan Sarkar, not Nandan Sengupta.
2. The author's name in "India - an experience" is spelt Simon Markett, not Murkett.
3. Ritisha Baidyaray's age was 10 years, not 11.
4. The heading for Tanima Dhar's article should read "My Bong way of learning hangul mal (Korean language)", and not "A Bong learns Hangul Mal".

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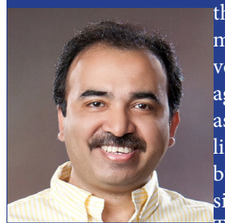
From the president's desk

As president of the Indian Cultural Society of Cambridge in UK, I feel privileged to be working alongside a remarkable group of dedicated members. The management committee sincerely wishes to uphold the views and needs of the membership.

Each member of the organisation comes with a unique set of talents and experiences that helps build the organisation even better. The areas of focus have been diverse — event planning, their delivery, membership and volunteer management. We as a group believe strongly in building a cohesive community. To achieve our mission, I recognise the value of sharing ideas and resources with like-minded individuals and invite more engagement in the process. The society is for you, our members, and like anything else in life, the more one puts into it, the more rewards are reaped.



I would also like to take this opportunity to acknowledge the important role you play in building our community. I am often awed by the passion, commitment, talents and enthusiasm that is unique to our volunteers. And so, I'd like to thank each and every one of you for inspiring and facilitating our activities.

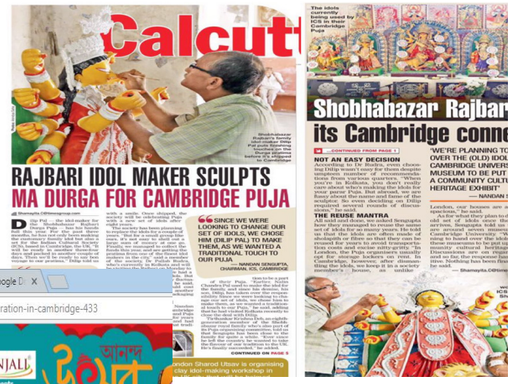
We are in the 15th year of our autumnal festival. I would take the opportunity to wish you and your family a very happy and prosperous Durga Puja 2017.

Yours sincerely,
Samratda

Dr Samrat Roychowdhury
President,
Indian Cultural Society,
Cambridge

ICS in Kolkata media

Our new idols, crafted by Dilip Pal, the sculptor of Sovabazar Rajbari, were featured in Calcutta Times in July.



An article by our senior member Sima Chakrabarti on the ICS Puja featured in Anandabar Patrika's "Ananda Utsav" section in October 2016.

AN APPEAL

This year, we have procured a new set of idols from Kolkata. We thank all our members and supporters who have donated to the Murti Fund, and take this opportunity to appeal for further donations. The fund will be kept open for a few more months. If you wish to donate, or would like to enquire about the matter, please get in touch with us at:

contact@indianculturalsociety.co.uk

ICS joins hands with Ethnic Forum

Sohini Datta Biswas

This year saw the first joint venture between the Indian Cultural Society and the Cambridge Ethnic Community Forum in organising an art and craft session for the women and children of the Bangladeshi community.

The women had a fantastic time learning how to make necklaces using wooden beads and bits of spare cloth from our resident craft enthusiast Tanima Dhar.

While their mums crafted and chatted, the children got busy with crayons for an art contest. Three prizes were awarded to the best works and were won by Mohammed (5yrs) and Humaira (9yrs) for their e-xcellent drawings.

With tea and cakes to help things along, it provided an afternoon of cheer and bonhomie all around.

Pics: Sohini Datta Biswas

(From top) Two young participants at the art contest; Tanima Dhar conducts the craft session; some of the art produced by the contestants; CECF chief executive Eddie Stadnik and ICS volunteers pose with the Bangladeshi ladies as they show off the necklaces they made.

Pic: Abhijit Kar Gupta/Wlkimedia Commons

গেয়ে যায় অচিন পাখি

নবকুমার বসু

খুব পরিচিত দুটো লাইন বারবার ভেসে বেড়াচ্ছে মনের মধ্যে। এক "আশ্বিনের মাঝামাঝি উঠিল বাজনা বাজি ... । দুই হল "যেতে পারি কিন্তু কেন যাব। ভাবি, একি শুধু আমার, নাকি সময়ের নিরিখে আরও অনেক প্রবাসী মনেই গুনগুনোচ্ছে অমন দু-লাইন। কেমন এক উদাসী উড়ুউড়ু ভাব যেন মনের ..

এই সেদিন থেকে, যেদিন কল্পনার চোখে প্রবাসী বঙ্গসন্তান দেখতে লাগল আকাশকে ছুটি দিয়ে, মুক্ত করে ধূসর মেঘের দঙ্গল ফিরে গেল। আর হঠাৎ উদোম হয়ে গেল ঝকঝকে নীল ... নীল আকাশ। বৃষ্টি-ধোয়া গাছের পাতায় পিছলে পড়তে লাগল রোদ্দুর... ফুরফুরিয়ে এল হাওয়া ... আর মুচকি হাসির মতো ভেসে যেতে থাকল সাদা মেঘের ওড়না। কি যেন একটা খবর হয়ে গেছে প্রকৃতির কোনায় কোনায়। পুকুর-দীঘিতে জল টলটল করছে অথচ মাঠঘাট শুকিয়ে আসছে। কার্নিশ-অলিন্দ- ভেজা দেওয়ালে জলের মানচিত্র উবে যাচ্ছে। শিশিরে শিউলিও কি !

সুদুর প্রবাস থেকে মায়ের সঙ্গে টেলিফোনে কথা বলতে বলতে মেয়ের মন কেমন উদাস হয়ে যায়। চোখের ওপর আঁকা হয়ে যাচ্ছে সেই পূজো পূজো ঘোর... কাঁপা কাঁপা হাওয়ায় কানে ভেসে আসছে ঢাকের আওয়াজ, প্যান্ডেলের বাঁশ পড়ছে পাড়ার মাঠে। গভীর রাতেও ঠাকুরের মঞ্চ তৈরির ঠুকঠুক শব্দ ... নতুন শাড়ির গন্ধ। টেলিফোন হাতে ধরা, তবু কথা থেমে যায়। মায়ের ডাকে চমক ভাঙ্গে

হ্যাঁ রে, কি হল ? এবার পূজোয় তোরা আসবি নাকি ?

না মা, হবে না, নীল আর টিঙ্কুর ছুটি নেই... সন্দীপেরও খুব কাজের চাপ... হাজারটা দায়িত্ব বাড়িতে আমার।

দেশ থেকেও মেয়ের মন পড়ে নিতে পারেন মা। দুজনের চোখ মেদুর হয়ে আসে। নীরবতাই বাঙ্ময় হয়ে থাকে। নাহ, আর কিছু করার থাকেনা। কোথাও একটা গোপন দীর্ঘশ্বাস পড়ে। বাঙ্গালির এ সময়ে। তাহলেও... এই তো জীবন কালীদা...!

দেবী দুর্গা মর্ত্যের মেয়ে উমা হয়ে বাপের বাড়িতে আসবেন ছেলেপুলে নিয়ে এই ছবিতে আশৈশব স্বপ্নমাখা ঘোর বঙ্গসন্তানের। একদিন শৈশব-বাল্যকাল শেষ হয়ে এসে যায় কিশোরবেলা। টানাপোড়েনের বয়েস থেকে টের পেয়েছিলাম, আশ্বিনের মাঝামাঝি সত্যিই একটা বাজনা বেজে ওঠে। গঞ্জ-মফঃস্বলের মানুষ - শহুরে চালবাজি শিখিনি। দাদামশায় পণ্ডিত মুখুজ্জে বামুন। পিতৃপরিচয়ে অধম কায়স্থ সন্তান হলেও , দাদু আমার গুরু। সাবেক আমলের দালানকোঠার মামারবাড়ি, সামনে ছড়ানো বাগান। স্কুলের ছুটি পড়ার আগে থাকতেই মামারবাড়ির বাগানে শিশিরভেজা ঘাসের ওপর সাদা হয়ে পড়ে থাকে তাজা শিউলিফুল। পড়তে বসার আগে সাজি ভর্তি করে তুলে আনি। জলের ছিটে দিয়ে ঠাকুরের সামনে... ঘর ভরে থাকে সুগন্ধে। তারপর হয় চণ্ডীপাঠ। ভোরের হাওয়ায় পাঁচিল ঘেঁষে দোলে কাশফুলের ডাঁটি। কোথাও বাজনা বাজে... ।

বেলা হতে ফিরে আসতাম নিজেদের বাড়ি। এবাড়িতে তখনও পূজোর হাওয়া আসেনি। বাবার পূজো সংখ্যার লেখা তখনো শেষ হয়নি যে। ওদিকে পাড়ার মাঠে চট ত্রিপল ডাঁই হয়ে এসে পড়ছে। উত্তেজনা টানটান হতেই মহালয়ার ভোর... নাহ মাইক বাজত না। পাড়ার অনেক বাড়িতেই রেডিও তখন...সম্মিলিত শঙ্খধ্বনি প্রতিধ্বনিত হয়ে ফিরছে পাড়ার মধ্যে। তারপর বীরেন্দ্রকৃষ্ণ ভদ্র আর একটু শুনতে শুনতে আবার ঘুমিয়ে পড়া।

কদিন পর ঠাকুর আসবে প্যাণ্ডেলে। কোন জামা কবে পরা হবে তার কতো হিসেব যে ছিল! পাড়ার মেয়েদের সাথে চোখাচোখি হবে, নিজেকে হিরো প্রমাণ করার কি যে প্রচেষ্টা! তবু কি দ্রুত ফুরিয়ে যেত দিনগুলো। দশমীর দিন সন্ধ্যা...ফাঁকা প্যাণ্ডেল। ঠাকুরের মঞ্চে মাত্র একটা বড় প্রদীপ জ্বলছে... ইলেক্ট্রিসিয়ান গোপালদা সব তার খুলে নিয়ে গেছে। কি মোচড় বুকের মধ্যে !

তারপর জীবন ঘাট পাল্টাতে লাগল। পৃথিবীর রঙ বদল শুরু হয়ে গেল। তারও আরেক ছন্দ। পরিবর্তন প্রকৃতির নিয়ম। জীবন নদী তারই অনুষঙ্গে আঁকেবাঁকে চলে কখনও জোয়ার, কখনও ভাঁটায়। কিন্তু থেমে যায় না। কবে যেন পার হয়ে যায় কালাপানি । তারপর ফিরে যাব কি যাব-না করতে করতেই খেয়াল হয়, দিনযাপনের শেকড়বাকড় চারিয়ে গেছে প্রবাসের মাটির গভীরে...খুব সহজে তাকে উপড়ে তোলা যাচ্ছে না। পরিচয়ে ছাপ পড়ে যায় "প্রবাসী'।

তাতেই বা কি! হাজার কাজ, ব্যস্ততার মধ্যেও যে সেই...আশ্বিনের মাঝামাঝি...। কাউকে বলে দিতে হয়নি...সে আপনি বাজে। সে যেন এক অচিন পাখির ডাক। দেখা যায় না, তবু শোনা যায়। আর শুরু হয় এক দোলাচল...অনেক বছর পর আবার কি একবার যাওয়া যায় দেশে? সেই মেঘলাভাঙ্গা রোদ যেখানে প্রকৃতিকে উদাস করে নিয়ে আসে আগমনী বার্তা। নাহ্, হয়ে ওঠে না। সময়ের টানাটানি... তাছাড়া ধকল আছে...খরচও কম নয় উড়ানের। ...ঠিক, আরও কিছুও আছে।

পরিবর্তনের ঢেউ লেগেছে দেশেও যে! ভেবেছিলাম, আমার চোখ বুঝি এতদিনের ব্যবধানে অন্যরকম দেখছে। তাই কি? না, সবটা তা নয়।

আশ্বিনের মাঝামাঝি দেশেই যেন সেই বাজনাটা ভাল শোনা যায় না আর। চতুর্দিকে

বড় হইচই আর গোলমাল। লোকজন জোরে জোরে কথা বলে। ভোরের সেই স্নিগ্ধ হাওয়াটাই হারিয়ে গেছে। নীলাভ নয়, আকাশ ধূসর বর্ণ। শিউলি মরকুটে । পাড়ার পূজোর সেই বড় মাঠগুলো আর নেই। সেখানে সব বহুতল। পূজোর নাম হয়েছে আবাসনের পূজো। সেখানে দলাদলি আর পলিটিক্স। তুমি বিদেশে থাকো? তোমার চাঁদা তিনগুন বেশী। বাজার এমনিতেই আগুন।

আর বড় বড় শহুরে যে সব পুজো...সিমলা, কলেজ স্কোয়ার, মহম্মদ আলী পার্ক, পার্ক সার্কাস, ম্যাডক্স স্কোয়ার, তেইশ পল্লী, একডালিয়া, বোসপুকুর, মুক্তধারা, মুদিয়ালি...নাহ্, সেখানে পৌছান যায় না। সেখানকার ব্যবস্থা কর্পোরেট হাউসের মতো। পূজোর থেকে সেখানে আড়ম্বর বেশী। ভিআইপি ছাড়া পাত্তা পাবে না। ঠাকুর দেখার জন্য কার্ড পেতে হয়।

মনটা কেমন সেঁতিয়ে যায়। চেষ্টা করলে একবার কি যেতে পারি না! নিশ্চয়ই পারি। তারপরেই মনে আসে – কেন যাব! এখনও তো স্বপ্নের ফ্রেমে বাঁধানো সেই ছবিটা অটুট আছে। একটু স্মৃতির ধূলো ঝেড়ে নিলেই পূজো পূজো সব ছবি ঝলমল। দেশে যে সেই স্বপ্নময় ছবির ফ্রেমটাই ভেঙ্গে তছনছ হয়ে গেছে। বাজনা শুনেও তাই ভাবি, কেন যাব! এ বড় টানাপোড়েন। বরং এই প্রবাসে বসেই সেই অচিন পাখিটার ডাক শুনতে শুনতে আর এক নতুন স্বপ্নের জাল বুনতে পারি হয়তো...।

দেশের ডি আই পি পুজোর হর্তাগোনে সেই অচিন পাখির ডাক ক্রমশ ক্ষীন হয়ে এসেছে

Nabakumar Basu is an established name in contemporary Bengali literature. His large ouvre includes Chirosokha, the longest Bengali novel in recent times that was serialised in Desh, and the critically acclaimed Srimoyee Ma

Pic: Wikimedia Commons

Pratima-puja in Hinduism: Its origins and significance

Julius Lipner

The editor of this excellent magazine has kindly asked me to contribute a small piece for this edition on the topic mentioned in the title. I am happy to do so since earlier this year I published a book entitled, Hindu Image-Worship with special reference to Vaisnavism: A Philosophical-Theological Inquiry (Routledge, 2017). Thus, the topic is fresh in my mind.

Hinduism is largely identified, if not defined, in the public mind by the making and worship of images (even though, as we know, there are some traditions in Hinduism, like Brahmoism and the Arya Samaj, that reject image-worship). But in the public eye, Hinduism is closely linked to images depicting that wonderful and sometimes fearsome panorama of gods and goddesses, usually associated with some animal or other as a vehicle or mount (vahana), and colourfully portrayed often with multiple heads and arms, the latter holding objects of various kinds (ayudha).

Do Hindus, who have produced from ancient times sophisticated systems of logic, grammar, philosophy, theology and evidence-based inquiry, really believe there are many deities, who actually look like this? What is going on here? What is the significance of the elaborate ritual involved in image-worship, e.g. inviting the deity to occupy the image (avahana), chanting mantras and hymns (stuti), bathing the image (snana), offering flowers (nirmalya) and food (naivedya) etc. etc., and, finally, dismissing the deity (visarjana)? And when did the practice of image-worship begin? Let us look briefly into these questions, starting with the last one first.

As you may know, archaeologists speak of two early urban cultures in India: (a) the first urbanisation, as it is called, was that of the Harappan culture, which spread widely from around the Indus river in the north-west of the subcontinent and peaked at about 2400 BCE; (b) the second urbanisation is dated from about 600 BCE, with Mathura in northern India later becoming one of its main centres. We cannot speak with certainty about image-worship in the Harappan culture. No doubt, various statues and terracotta figurines have been found from this civilisation, but it is not clear what their significance was.

(above) Kali is one of the many forms of Mahamaya; and (facing page) elaborate rituals are integral to image worship.

This is because we have insufficient evidence. For example, we still have not interpreted the script of this culture. So, all we can do is make an intelligent guess.

Personally, I would conjecture that a number of these images had some sort of religious significance; a good example is a figure depicted on a small seal whose posture resembles a modern yogi seated in padmasana or the lotus position. We certainly cannot say for sure that theologically any of these figures are genuine precursors of modern Hindu images. We simply don't know enough. So, we must leave interpretation of these images to one side till we have firmer evidence, and move on to the images of the second, much later, urban period.

Here, we have clearer textual and material evidence. From about 600-500 BCE there is evidence that religious images, resembling precursors of modern mainstream images, and a little later, temples of stone to house some of these images, existed. This process may have started even earlier with temples made from wood but we have no surviving evidence of this. Images of a Mother Goddess fighting a buffalo enemy, of Vishnu etc. with multiple hands become more and more plentiful already by the first few centuries of the Common Era.

What, we may ask, was the purpose artistically of giving such images many hands, and in some cases, more than one head? There is a theory about, that this practice arose from the description of certain devas or gods in the Veda as visvarupa or "omniform", capable of creating or producing different kinds of being in our world. The many arms and heads, says this theory, is a later artistic device to indicate the universal, creative power of such deities. But I have given quite a lot of space in my book to show that this cannot be right, for there are such creative devas in the Veda who are not given multiple hands and heads in later Hindu art, while there is an important deity from early Vedic times not mentioned in the Veda, i.e. the Mother Goddess, who was given the early characteristic of at least many arms.

I believe that I have shown that giving many heads and arms/hands to gods and goddesses was an early and distinctive teaching device of the Hindus, viz. to show artistically the multiple powers — wisdom, insight, all-knowingness, skills in conquest of the enemy, guidance, generosity, protectiveness etc. etc. — that the deities could give to enhance and safeguard the lives of their devotees.

Pic: Sovan Sarkar

The ayudhas or objects in the various hands were/are instructive, visible symbols of these divine powers. That is all. Numerous texts from the Mahabharata and the Puranas support this interpretation. There is no grand metaphysical theory underlying this practice.

Now we may ask: do Hindus believe that there are really many gods and goddesses? Are Hindus polytheists, in opposition to Muslims, Christians and Jews who are monotheists or believers in only one God? To answer, we must make careful distinctions (which most Hindus make).

(High) Hindu theology generally maintains that ultimately there is only one God or Supreme Being, which is usually described as essentially self-aware spirit (atman), all-knowing (sarvajna), all-powerful (satyasamkalpa), kindly and compassionate (karuna) etc., and the source of all finite being. Unlike Jews, Muslims and Christians, Hindus go on to say this Supreme Being also can take on different personalised forms (rupas) as avataras, vyuhas etc. among us to aid and abet the welfare and salvation of the whole world (lokasamgraha). So here one God has many forms.

Mythologically, these many forms are given separate personalities and stories (itihasa) to teach us religious and life-enhancing truths. But theologically these different rupas all derive from and are sourced in the One. Thus Hindus are both polytheists and monotheists from different perspectives. When speaking of the One Mother Goddess in her form as Mahamaya, the Kalika Purana explains this theological relationship well: "Just as rays of the sun continually come forth from the sun's disc, so Ugracanda and the others (viz. subsidiary forms of the Goddess) come forth from the body of the Goddess Mahamaya". The one Goddess has many forms, and the images of these forms, if worshipped properly, lead the devotee to the One residing within. Most Hindus who have been instructed in their faith, understand this.

We may now inquire about the deity's association with its image during worship. There are a number of theological positions about this. I shall focus on the two most widely held: first, the presence of the deity in the visualised image. This is a well-known practice, especially in Tantra. Here a particular deity is ritually visualised in accordance with scriptural texts, and is also ritually invoked to reside as this mental image. The visualised, mental image becomes the deity and often interacts with the devotee/sadhaka. Alternatively, there is a physical, usually three-dimensional image, external to the devotee, which is invested with the deity's presence by a ritualised process called the prana-pratistha. This "enlivening" of the image is supposed to actually alter the matter of the image, often into a substance called suddha-sattva which is identified with the deity. The image may look and act as the material out of which the image is made (you can break it, dent it etc.), but in fact substantially it is not so: by the grace of the deity, it is "deified", and therefore a proper object of worship. This justifies all the rituals of worship mentioned earlier in this article (snana, naivedya, nirmalya etc.) patterned on reverence for a royal personage. The aim of the deity's "descent" into the image (arca-avatara) is direct accessibility for the devotee, out of the deity's kindness and love. Out of compassion, the Transcendent becomes immanent in our daily lives.

There is much more to say, but space is limited. One final point: image-worship in Hinduism depends on an act of faith by the worshipper. The worshipper is tacitly saying, "I wish to exist in a universe which is presided over by a compassionate and caring God who will sustain us — not only me — and build us up through the travails of this world and finally share eternity with him/her in a loving relationship". Not to believe this is also to make an act of faith of a different sort. Either way, one is free to believe in one or the other of these alternatives — and to take the consequences.

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চন্দ্রকেতুগড়

দিলীপ কুমার চক্রবর্তী

চন্দ্রকেতুগড় খননকার্য্য কিছুটা স্তিমিত ভাবে আশুতোষ মিউজিয়ামের উদ্যোগে , যা কোলকাতা বিশ্ববিদ্যালয়ের অঙ্গ, ১৯৫৬ থেকে বহু বৎসর পরিচালিত হয়। আমি যখন যাই তখন দায়িত্বে ছিলেন চিত্তরঞ্জন রায় চৌধুরী এবং ওঁর ওপরে ছিলেন দেবপ্রসাদ ঘোষ যিনি প্রাচীন ভারতীয় ইতিহাসের অধ্যাপক এবং আশুতোষ মিউজিয়ামের অধিকর্তা।

আমাদের সময় বাস যেত শ্যামবাজার মোড় থেকে, ঘন্টাখানেক লাগত, বারাসত - বসিরহাট রাস্তায় চন্দ্রকেতুগড়। প্রাকার দিয়ে ঘেরা একটি সুপ্রাচীন নগরী, যদিও প্রাকারের বাইরে বহু নিদর্শন পাওয়া গেছে। মৌর্য্য যুগ থেকে তো নিশ্চয়ই, তবে আরো কিছু পুরনোও হতে পারে। এই কেন্দ্রটির একটি বৈশিষ্ট্য - প্রচুর পরিমাণে পোড়ামাটির যক্ষিণীমূর্ত্তি এবং

অন্যান্য বিভিন্ন রকমের অলংকৃত ফলক, যাতে মুদী দোকান থেকে মৈথুন দৃশ্য সব চিত্রিত আছে। খেতে চাষ করার সময়, পুকর কাটা বা অন্যভাবে মাটি কাটার সময় গ্রামের লোক এই ধরনের ফলক অথবা পাথরের পুঁতি প্রচুর পরিমাণে পান। ১৯৫০ এর দশক থেকেই যাদুঘর-পুরাতত্বের লোকেরা অথবা সাধারণ শিক্ষিত মানুষ এগুলি সংগ্রহ করেন গ্রামের লোকও এগুলি বিক্রয় করতে ইতস্ততঃ করেন না।

এইসব নিদর্শন বিক্রি করা নিয়ে একটা কথা আছে। আদি যুগে -১৯৭০ এর দশক পর্য্যন্ত আমি জানি - অল্প পয়সাতেই এগুলো বিক্রি হতো, এমনকি বিনি পয়সাতেও পাওয়া যেত। রাখাল ছেলেদের বিড়ি সিগারেট দিয়ে আমি নিজে ২/১ টা এই ধরনের ফলক পেয়েছি। কি পরিমাণে পাওয়া যেত, তা আরেকটি ঘটনা জানিয়ে বলছি। বারাসত-দেগঙ্গার অদূরে বলে চন্দ্রকেতুগড় যাওয়াটা কখনও সমস্যা ছিলনা। চিত্তদাই খননকার্য্য পরিচালনা করছিলেন। দুপুরে লোটা নিয়ে মাঠে গেছেন। মাঠে বসেই দেখলেন শেয়ালের তোলা মাটিতে একটি সম্পূর্ণ পোড়ামাটির সুঙ্গ যুগের যক্ষিণী মূর্তি পড়ে আছে। চিত্তদা যখন নিয়ে আসছেন তখন আমিও দেখেছি।

এখন হয়তো এই পরিমাণে পাওয়া যায়না, কিন্তু বহু বছর ধরে যে পরিমাণে পাওয়া গেছে, তাতেই পৃথিবীর বহু মিউজিয়ামে চন্দ্রকেতুগড়ের পোড়ামাটির মূর্ত্তি স্থান পেয়েছে। এছাড়া ব্যাক্তিগত সংগ্রহ তো আছেই। হাবড়ার অধ্যাপক গৌরীশংকর দে ও পাটনার শ্রী বিনোদ কানোরিয়ার ব্যাক্তিগত সংগ্রহ দেখার সৌভাগ্য আমার হয়েছে। অধ্যাপক দে'র সংগ্রহ শুধু চন্দ্রকেতুগড় আর শ্রী কানোরিয়ার সংগ্রহ চন্দ্রকেতুগড় ও আরো বহু স্থানের। পাটনায় বসেই চন্দ্রকেতুগড়ের প্রাচীন জিনিষ সংগ্রহ করা যায় চন্দ্রকেতুগড় যেতে হয়না। তার অর্থ - মূর্ত্তি বা প্রাচীন বস্তু গ্রামের লোকের হাতে আবিষ্কার হওয়ার পরে, কিছু লোক আছেন যারা গ্রামের লোকের সঙ্গে যোগাযোগ রাখেন। ওদের কাছ থেকে অপেক্ষাকৃত কম দামে কেনেন কোথায় কোন সংগ্রাহকের কাছে বেশী দাম পাওয়া যায় তা জানেন এবং তাদের কাছে পৌঁছে দেন। এই সংগ্রাহকদের কেউ কেউ আবার বিদেশের সংগ্রাহকদের সঙ্গে যোগসূত্র রাখেন এবং বিভিন্ন মাধ্যমে পাঠিয়ে দেন তাঁদের কাছে। চন্দ্রকেতুগড়ের বহু পোড়ামাটির মূর্ত্তির জন্য ১৯৬০/৭০'র দশকে গ্রামের রাখাল বালক ১৫/২০ টাকার বেশী চাওয়ার কথা কল্পনা করতে পারতো না। আমি নিজে ৫ টাকার বেশী দিয়েছি বলে মনে পড়ছেনা ! বিশেষ শিল্পবিক্রীর কোম্পানীগুলোর ক্যাটালগে এখন দাম মুদ্রিত থাকে ৪/৫ হাজার পাউণ্ড । অতিরঞ্জন নেই।

চন্দ্রকেতুগড়ের একটি ফলকে দেখতে পাওয়া যায় একটি গ্রামের ঘর , বারান্দায় একহাতে কাঠের খুঁটি ধরে একটি মহিলা বসে আছেন , উঠোনে গাছ এবং চাষবাস কাজের জন্য তৈরি কয়েকটি পুরুষ ও নারী। সামনে একটি বাছুর নিয়ে দাঁড়ানো গরুর সঙ্গে একটি দুধ দোহানো স্ত্রী-মূর্তি। পুরোটাই সুঙ্গ যুগের (খৃষ্টপূর্ব দ্বিতীয় বা প্রথম শতক) শিল্প-সুষমার নিদর্শন । অপর আরেকটি ফলকে দেখা যায় স্ত্রী-মূর্তির প্রতিকৃতি -

পোড়ামাটিতেই কিন্তু অলঙ্কার বিহীন । যা আমাদের স্ত্রী মূর্ত্তির ক্ষেত্রে প্রায় অসম্ভব। পাটনার বিনোদ কানোরিয়ার সংগ্রহেই দেখেছি দুইতই পোড়ামাটির বালকের মাথা পাতার মালাতে ঘেরা। নিশ্চিত ভূমধ্যসাগরীয় প্রভাব। চন্দ্রকেতুগড় যে ভূমধ্যসাগরীয় বাণিজ্যের এক্তিয়ারে ছিল সে বিষয়ে কোনো সন্দেহ নেই। প্রত্যক্ষ ভাবে ঐ অঞ্চলের বণিকরা আসতেন এবং সাথে নিজের অঞ্চলের কিছু শিল্পকীর্ত্তিও আনতেন। আমাদের দেশীয় শিল্পীরা তাদের পোড়ামাটির শিল্পে কিছু বহিরাগত শিল্পের রূপ দিতেন।

শ্রী কানোরিয়ার সংগ্রহেই দেখেছিলাম চন্দ্রকেতুগড়ের হাতীর দাঁত্যার কাজ। আর ছিল কাঁচ ও বিভিন্ন পাথরের পুঁতি - সহস্র সহস্র । অনুপাতে কারনেলিয়ান পাথরের পুঁতিই বেশী। এই পুঁতি শুধু চন্দ্রকেতুগড়েই ছিল না। চন্দ্রকেতুগড় ছিল বিদ্যাধরী নদীর উপত্যকাতে। আদিগঙ্গা ধরে যে সমসাময়িক কেন্দ্রগুলো ছিল তার মধ্যে একটি ছিল বৃহত্তর কলকাতার ভেতরেই - দমদমে ক্লাইভ কুঠির নীচে, সেখানে অগুনতি পাথরের পুঁতি ও অন্যান্য পুরাতাত্বিক সামগ্রী পাওয়া গেছে। এখানেও তারিখ খৃষ্টপূর্ব তৃতীয় শতাব্দী বা তার আগের। কলকাতা নগরীর সূত্রপাত জব চার্ণকের অন্ততঃ দু হাজার বছর আগে।

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ব্রেক্সিটের ব্রিক্সামে

তীর্থঙ্কর বন্দ্যোপাধ্যায়

ডেভনের টরকি থেকে ফেরিতে ঘন্টাখানেক। লাইন দিয়ে ফেরিতে ওঠার সময় মার্কিন সহযাত্রী তার সঙ্গীকে বললেন শুনলাম। “এটা টরবে।” - বে মানে খাঁড়ি। সাগর যেখানে তীরের খাঁজে ঢুকে পড়েছে। -- কোন সাগর? ভূগোলে আমি চিরকালই কাঁচা। সেই কবে মাধ্যমিক পরীক্ষার পরে সন্তোষপুরে বন্ধুর বাড়ি যাব বলে বেরিয়ে ২০৬ নম্বর বাসে পার্ক স্ট্রিটে পৌছে গিয়েছিলাম। সময় পেরোনো পাতাল রেলের কাজ তখনো চলছে। ডাঁই করা মাটির স্তুপ দেখে সেদিন ঠাওর হয়েছিলো, আমি গন্তব্যের একেবারে বিপরীত প্রান্তে। তাই এবারে আর ঝুঁকি নেওয়া নেই। ফেরিতে উঠেই সোজা সারেঙ ’ র কাছে। আমার শিশুসুলভ কৌতূহল দেখে কতটা খুশি হলেন জানিনা, তবে মুখাবয়ব দেখে মনে হল কিঞ্চিৎ বিরক্তই হয়েছেন আমার অজ্ঞতায়।
- ইংলিশ চ্যানেল !

উনবিংশ শতাব্দীর গোড়ার দিকে ওয়াটারলু’ র যুদ্ধে পরাজিত নেপোলিয়নকে এই টরবেতেই প্রথম আনা হয়েছিল, তারপর সেন্ট হেলেনার দ্বীপে নির্বাসন। প্রবল পরাক্রমশালী নেপোলিয়নকে যেখানে জোর করে আনা হয়েছিল সেখানে আমি স্বেচ্ছায় এসেছি বটে, তাও টরবে’ র সূত্রে দুশো বছরের ব্যবধানে আমাদের মধ্যে যে একরকম যোগসূত্র তৈরী হল তা ভেবে আমার তখন হাঁ অবস্থা। ইতিহাসের কথা ভেবে নয় - বরং পলিটিক্যাল-ইকনমি’ র নেশাতেই ইস্টারের ছুটির গন্তব্য হিসেবে ইংল্যান্ডের দক্ষিণ-পশ্চিম প্রান্তের ডেভনকে বেছেছিলাম। এখানে ভোটদাতাদের একটা বড় অংশ ব্রেক্সিটের পক্ষে রায় দিয়েছেন। তাই আশা ছিল ছুটির ফাঁকে তাঁদের মনস্তত্ত্বটাও একটু বুঝে নেওয়ার।

ইংল্যান্ডের মধ্যে ব্রিক্সেমেই সবচেয়ে বেশি মাছ ধরা হত। সপ্তাহে গড়ে ১৫০ টন। প্রায় তিনশো মাছ ধরার নৌকা আর দেড় হাজারেরও বেশি জেলে। “তারপরে রেললাইন বসলো” , স্মৃতির সরণি বেয়ে বংশ পরম্পরায় জানা কথা বলে চলেন প্রৌঢ়। “তখন শোল, প্লেইস, হেরিং, হুইটিং-ই আসত বেশি। তার মধ্যে ভালোগুলো পাঠানো হত লন্ডন, বাথ, ব্রিস্টল, এক্সেটার-এ। রেলের সুবাদে আট ঘন্টায় সেরা মাছগুলো পৌছে যেত লন্ডনের বিলিংসগেট মাছ বাজারে। ” নানা চড়াই উতরাই-এর মধ্যে দিয়ে, প্রযুক্তির নানান ওঠানামার সাথে নিজেদের মানিয়ে নিয়েছেন ওখানকার জেলেরা। ইংল্যান্ডের মধ্যে নিজেদের অবস্থান এবং গুরুত্ব বজায় রাখতে পারলেও ইউরোপের মধ্যে অন্যান্য দেশের প্রবল প্রতিযোগিতার মুখোমুখি হয় ব্রিক্সেম।

“ব্রাসেলসই ঠিক করে দিত সমুদ্রের মধ্যে কতটা জায়গাজুড়ে ব্রিটিশ জেলেরা মাছ ধরতে পারবেন,” বলে চলেন ফিলিপ হ্যানাফোর্ড। “আমরা আমাদের জলসীমা ফিরে পেতে চাই, যেখানে শুধুমাত্র আমাদেরই অধিকার থাকবে।” মাছ ব্যবসা ছেড়ে ব্রিক্সেম’ এর অনেকেই এখন ক্যাফে-দোকান খুলে ব্যবসা শুরু করেছেন। তৈরী হয়েছে মেরিনা। প্রমোদবিহারের জায়গার সামনেই নীরবে দাঁড়িয়ে সারি সারি মাছ ধরার ট্রলার।

“ইউ থেকে বেরিয়ে গেলে এগুলো আবার সচল হবে। প্রানবন্ত হবে এই জেলেনগরী। ব্রিক্সেম আবার নিজের আত্মাকে ফিরে পাবে।” দীর্ঘশ্বাস ফেলে বলেন ফিলিপ হ্যানাফোর্ড।

জোরে ওঁর হাতটা চেপে ধরি। প্রৌঢ়ের খসখস-এ হাতের

Tirthankar Bandyopadhyay is a London based writer with over 30 years experience in Journalism. He currently works with youth in skill development.

India – an experience

Simon Markett

I am a German man, married to a Bengali woman and together we live in Cambridge. Since we met in 2012 we have travelled to India four times. This is a collection of some of my impressions. Since it was a wedding that brought me to India, it is only fitting to start this article with some wedding talk.

Wedding seasons

I haven’t heard of any other place in the world that has a whole season just for weddings. But it does make sense: If you can call hundreds of people your friends — social circles can be so much more extensive than in the West — you would expect to be invited to quite a number of weddings every year. Thus, I had the honour of participating in Indian weddings on multiple occasions and in different roles. During our own engagement, I felt like a film star, standing on a pedestal, wearing my best Manyavar outfit, greeting guest after guest, shaking hand after hand, and smiling to the cameras till my jaw starting cramping! My sister-in-law’s wedding took place in a beautiful temple at the seaside in Kerala, among the massive joint family. .

So many languages

During one wedding, in a Gurudwara, men sat on one side of the room and women on the other. I ended up sitting away from anyone I knew. At some point during the ceremony I asked a friend of the bride sitting next to me, “What is the priest saying?” He replied laughing, “I don’t know, I don’t speak Punjabi”.

Only then did I realise how varied the Indian languages were, even though related to each other. The more impressive thing is how quickly many Indians pick up words from other languages. We learnt how handy this can be when hailing an auto in Bangalore: The driver would quote one price to me when I asked in English, drop to a much lower rate when my wife switched to Hindi, but only dropped to the final price when my sister-in-law threw in the Kannada she had picked up living in the city.

Sightseeing non-stop

When I talk about all the fantastic experiences and impressions that I bring back from travelling the country, I don’t know where to start and once I have started don’t know how to stop.

In Kolkata we visited the impressive Tagore mansion. How could one man have travelled so much, especially at a time when much fewer modes of transport were available? How could a writer writing in a regional language gain such fame across India, Britain, America, Germany, Russia, Japan and everywhere else in the world, at a time before books could be communicated and translated easily? I was in awe.

In Kerala it was all about nature. We went on trails through the jungle, where our guide, who was wearing sandals, would elegantly leap from one rock to the next and then wait for us to clamber up. We swam in the coldest and cleanest mountain spring while the sun was burning hot, and the whole trip came to its climax when we visited a resort, where we could ride and play with elephants!

In India, you get to act like a film star at your own wedding; (above) Kerala has some of the most gorgeous scenery.

We visited the Red Fort in Delhi and marvelled at the palace in Udaipur. We sat on a terrace in Jodhpur and watched monkeys chasing each other across the rooftops, rode camels through the Thar desert and slept on a dune under the stars. We observed Buddhist monks in Dharamsala, explored the Jama Masjid in Delhi and witnessed an aarti at the Birla temple in Kolkata.

Food, oh glorious food

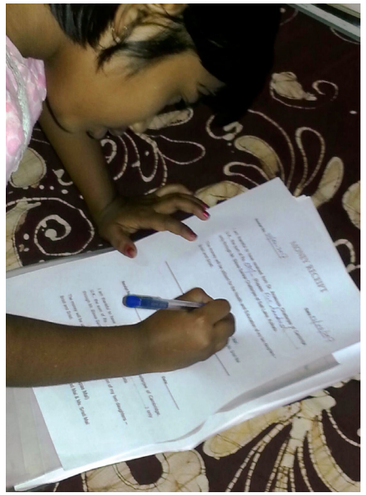
As I was a teenager I developed a particular taste for spicy food. Around the same time, I also gave up meat for good. I don’t believe in fate, but this undoubtedly prepared me for food in India. I am not saying that there isn’t plenty of non-spicy food — if you have ever had a rosogolla, you will never doubt that Kolkata has the best sweets in the world — or even non-veg food to go around, but it still such a great feeling to be spoiled for tasty choices wherever you are.

My wife still tells me that I am eating rooti the wrong way – you are supposed to dip them in your dal or eat with vegetable curries, not eat them as a snack on their own – but I think this might be the perfect metaphor for what I have learnt through my introduction to India: How to take in all new experiences and make them your own. And this definitely applies to more in life than just food!

Dr Simon Markett is a mathematician living and working in Cambridge.

Ay Brishti Jhe(n)pe: and here's to Rain!

Anasuya Chattopadhyay



Brishti with her sister Srishti, and (right) singing for her own cheque.

Brishti' is a chattering eight year old. Like the meaning of her name — Rain — she used to love running wild across the fields in her native West Bengal...but that was before she and her parents started battling her thalassemia.

Just £2 a month would allow Brishti and her sister to go to school! But at £900 annual income this was too dear for the family of six, much that they would have loved for this to happen...after all just medicines and nutrition for the girls were a bigger priority!

This is where the Cambridge story unfolded. Pam Rowling, a researcher at Cambridge and a mother of two girls herself, like me was struck to the core by the piercing truth in Brishti's grandmothers casual words, muttered as she was doing the dishes at our house in Kolkata where she works: "Jodie porabei na tale mere phello na keno." What was the point in keeping her alive without giving her an education!

Those words, from a woman who couldn't read or write or had never been to school herself, haunted us and slowly crystallised our resolve to change things. It started off with a cake sale at our University Department (a £100 and delicious cakes from all over the world flowed in), leading on to a Sitar and Sarod concert (£200 from a delightful afternoon of music) and finally a chip in from the University Society Sakhya (£150) not to forget our generous friends who put together another £50 and the smaller sums from our folks in Kolkata... Suddenly there was a bit more than £500 and a real chance that these girls didn't have to be taken off their school registers after all!

Today Brishti and her sister Srishti are back at school (at least for the next 3 years), there is a bank account that ring-fences their money and each month the family gets the princely sum of c £6 (Rs 500) that not only allows the two girls to pay their school fees but even allows them small luxuries — a pencil case, a school uniform, the occasional lollypop!

In a world that talks of empowering the girl child, one of the proudest moments, for that grandmother of hers and indeed for many of us who are now part of this story, was the day Brishti came in to sign for her own cheque. Oh the power of literacy!

For many of us who have lived and grown up in India, children living in poverty, inequity and squalor are a sad reality which we have come to accept. The scale of the problem is overwhelming, enough to make room for despair and allow us to slip into apathy and inaction...but maybe we could think about it differently — even if one little drop of rain somewhere is allowed to flourish, we will have done our bit and can look our children in the eye to say we leave behind a kinder world for them.

Aj bocchorkar diney, shobar bacha shukhe thak! Benche thak Brishti, gore uthuk Srishti!

PS: There are funds to keep these children in school for the next few years but not enough to see them through secondary school. Can you help?....If you would like to be part of efforts to help this family continue to send their kids to school, please get in touch with Anasuya (olierma@gmail.com)

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White

Nayana Chakrabarti

Din, am I touching you? Am I? Am I? I'm not touching you", Shahana asks. "See". As always, she is emphatic, convinced that she cannot be wrong. Shahana is six and three quarters. Sujata has learnt the difficult way that these three quarters of a year are very important to her granddaughter, as much a part of herself as her name, HiIamShahana-Iamsixandthreequarters.

There is a table nearby, and there are chairs but Sujata has spent a lifetime forgoing them in favour of the piri on which she and Shahana now sit-squat together, with Sujata holding her stainless steel plate in her hand. The piri's stubby little legs hug the floor, it holds grandmother and granddaughter close, somehow containing them against the combined armies of physics and gravity. There is not a millimetre to be had between them, a single hair would not be able to shimmy through. They are touching.

"Na shona, you are not", Sujata says.

Shahana and Sujata have been left alone together for lunch. And, as is the custom for whenever they are alone, Shahana has had hers and now she waits for her grandmother to finish so that they might take their siestas together. As far back as she can remember, Shahana has been told by her parents (well, Madhumita is punctilious to a fault but Siddhartha always feels the need to insist that he doesn't "believe in all these superstitions") that she mustn't touch Din when she is eating otherwise Din's meal will be spoilt and Din will remain hungry all day.

In the darkened dining room, with its high ceiling; its old, cracked, red, cement floors; its dark, pistachio green walls; its peeling, flaking cowlicks of paint; its polka-dotted vitiligo of exposed plaster of paris; its rickety shutters closed against hungry tomcats and the brazen burn of the noonday sun, Sujata relaxes the rules which she has steeled herself to live by. The presence of Shahana allows her to step outside herself for a little while, ponder the world as it might otherwise have been had Adarsha not been taken from her so soon, had she not been plunged into untimely widowhood and unexpected poverty, had not been faced with the challenge of raising two daughters by herself, had not been forced to depend on the occasional breeze of goodwill blown her way by the wishes, whims and occasional fancies of her two brothers and their wives.

Throwing herself into a life whose objectives where survival and existence, Sujata had learnt to play a part. At first that part had been played out of anger, its props had been carried in protest: the stark white borderless sari, the bare forehead (so striking on one who had always matched her teep to her sari), the interminable fasts, the strict and sudden vegetarian diet for one who had always relished her chhoto-macher-jhol and whose maacher-matha-diye-moong-dal had been unanimously celebrated, the near-fanatical avoidance of entho… Over time, she began to accept it all, she would wrap the white about her, taking as much care over this new business as she had once done over her taants and Assamese silks, and as she wrapped, she would beg for the serenity of the white to enter her soul. You are all the colours, she would tell herself, you are all the colours.

***

Shahana smiles. "Good", she says.

"Wouldn't it be easier to do your colouring on the bed?"

"No".

"Well, then, keep the colours inside the lines. Your sketch pens are flying everywhere".

"No! Mrs Adlam told us to colour-in outside the lines and make a bigger picture so that's exactly what I'm doing. It's pretty, right? It's pretty."

"Yes, didibhai, it is".

***

Sujata wakes with a start. The squawks and concertinas of impatient rickshawallahs and autowallahs and minibus drivers sounding their horns tell Sujata, without ceremony, that she has slept for much longer than she had intended. Eyes groggy with sleep, limbs heavy as if weighted down, Sujata brings the edge of her sari and dabs at her eyes. They water ceaselessly these days… That's when she sees it.

In the gathering dusk, she is able to see colours blooming where nothing has bloomed for eons. Sujata fumbles for her glasses and with their assistance, she is able to decipher a trail of flowers blossoming on her aanchal. Drawn by an untrained hand, they lead to a little uneven collection of rivers and mountains, little mud huts and squat little palm trees. There is a rocketship, there are stars and three moons.

"Do you like it?" A small voice asks, through the darkness.

Sujata's mouth trembles. What can she say?

SUPARNA'S SAREES

SUPARNA ROY
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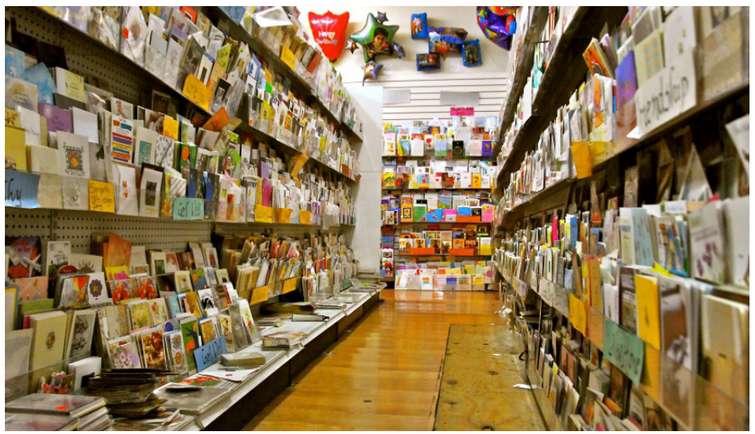
It's all on the cards!

Shamik Dhar



Confusion central, aka a card shop

The other day one of my friends was complaining that I never send them cards on any occasions, be it Christmas, be it New Year's eve, or be in Diwali. Frankly, I am pretty helpless in this matter. It's not that I forget about this in entirety, nor is the lack of interest to keep the fragile flame of friendship burning, but somehow it turns out that way.

To tell you the truth, I find it practically impossible to select a card for any specific personality. I feel whenever you send a card to someone it should always have your personal touch, be in accordance to the tastes of that personality you are sending, and associated with an acute aesthetic touch. According to some, the contents of the cards that you send, doesn't matter. They say, "It's always the love that is associated with it." I beg to differ. I feel it is always the content that matters, and that is probably why so many card shops have sprouted up.

I feel completely lost whenever I enter a card shop. The sheer array of the cards arranged neatly on the racks confuse me. Even though there are various sections that classify the cards — by the colour of the changing festive occasions and the changing seasons of the heart and in accordance to the myriad confusion of relations. However, the predominant section is dedicated to the youth and Cupid. It is the pleas of the enmeshed emotions which reign supreme.

Being young and romantic, I too, was not spared from Cupid's antics. It was the eyes that had mesmerized and captivated me. I felt I could immerse myself in the depths of those two eyes. Whenever I met her I wished I could let my heart speak, yet somehow it was quite impossible. The rational intellect insisted that there would always be a next time. The next time was probably tomorrow and that tomorrow never arrived. My intellect became the slave of my heart. It forced me to express my throbbing emotions somehow. It was then that I decided to visit my nearest card shop in search of some appropriate remedy.

As I pushed open the door the owner greeted me with a smile and his enormous tiger moustaches. I smiled back at the man whose moustaches were churned enough to balance a crow at each end. Quite confidently I started the work at hand. It didn't take me long to submerge myself in the maze of relations. It was after almost half an hour that I realised that I was completely lost.

When I finally looked up, I saw Sourav, my pal and bosom friend also approaching the card shop too. I could clearly see him through the tinted glass walls. Well, if he came to know of my weakness so would the whole world — getting spotted selecting a card before Valentine's Day, well nothing short of Hara-Kiri!

In blind panic I randomly picked a card from the special friend's section. It was a simple one and had a hell lot of daffodils. Out of sheer panic I handed the card to the shopkeeper who quickly took a note of its price and when he was about to hand me the card, I just said "Just a minute!" It was a cascading flow of the hand writing that attracted my attention, so I quickly asked him to write out the message of my emotions that had been so long raging inside me. As I dictated my short and simple message I kept an eye out for Sourav. He didn't seem his usual bubbly self; he seemed to be lost somewhere as he made his way through the ever-increasing traffic towards the shop. The shopkeeper quickly wrote down my message, put it back inside the envelope and placed it on the desk. Sourav was about to open the tinted glass door when I slipped behind one of the racks so that he would miss me. Strangely, he had missed me. He was heading straight for the Valentine's section, which surprised me even more.

I quietly pulled myself out from behind the rack and pocketed the change and slid the precious envelope under my shirt. Now it was my turn to catch him red-handed as I realised that he too was in the process of sending out heart racking messages to his intended sweetheart. He managed to select a card in no time, which annoyed me to an extent as I had failed in it miserably. As he was heading for the counter I crept behind him and tapped his shoulder. Poor guy, he was shocked out of his senses when he turned. I was the last person on earth he was expecting. I twitched both my eyebrows and gave him one of those looks that said "Got you man!"

Well there could be no excuse because the very previous day we two had spoken at length to convince the other guys on the futility of sending such messages when the matter could be better dealt by speaking directly to the object of your affection. He turned red and started sweating. I decided to give the poor guy a break: "Well, well….I promise to keep this under wraps if you wish but only if you tell me her identity." He meekly nodded and blurted out the name of the lady and scampered out of the shop.

Thanking God, I too ran out. I decided not to follow him but carry of this mission of mine secretly. Well, he too must have been thanking his stars for getting rid of me so easily for the time being. I headed straight to the post office and posted my fate with a five-rupee stamp. It was the waiting for the deliverance that still scares me. I was in a worse position than Sourav, because he could now speak of his fears and aspirations to me. I, on the other hand, couldn't, afraid to let go my dominant position as an individual who is unaffected by such trifle emotions as "Love". Whenever the phone rang, I hoped it to be from the queen of my heart. The restless feeling continued to haunt. It felt like I was being torn apart one limb at a time. Then, one fine afternoon the phone rang and it was indeed my "crush" on the line.

"Did you send me a card Shamik?"

I meekly admitted that I had.

"Can you come to the District Park now?"

"Now?"

"Yes"

"Why not! I will make it!" I said.

Then the line went dead.

There were butterflies in my stomach.

Hope springs eternal. I had to make it. My heart seemed willing to pop out of my mouth. I couldn't stop myself from trying to out jump my leaping heart and stopped only when I realised my younger brother was watching me wide-eyed. I quickly shaved and dressed before rushing out to her. It was dusk and the moon was lost somewhere. She stood like Diana. I wanted to get so close to her that I could touch her breath. But my rational mind forbade me. It was then she delivered "Take your card and go to hell!" as the ashes of my hopes lay scattered.

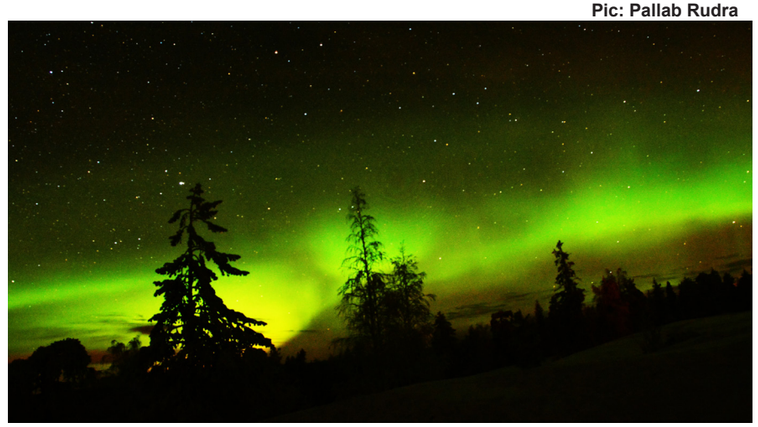
With due regards to my "crush" and the SPECIAL FRIEND'S section, it was the last time I ever sent a card to anyone. When I opened the envelope out fell the daffodils, the testimony of my misfortune and it was perchance that I happened to open it to have a last look. Even though the message bore her name on top, beneath them were the printed "Happy Birthday". And the three-letter word that had sealed my fate followed: "Mom". Underneath, this three letter word was scripted my proud name "Shamik Dhar".

Being the joker let me dedicate this to the queen of my heart!

Shamik Dhar is a Kolkata-based short story writer and a project engineer at C-DAC. You can enjoy some of his short stories at www.storystar.com.

A night of Arctic adventure

Pallab Rudra and
Sonela Basak



Pic: Pallab Rudra

Suddenly in that Stygian darkness, I could see a faraway twinkle. My heart skipped a beat "Clear sky, so we have a good chance tonight". This would be our third. No words can possibly describe the actual feeling; I was in complete shock when it happened first time. I still am.

Our snowmobiles had glided from Rovaniemi through the Arctic wilderness swathed in snow to Ounasvaara Fell. We had climbed up the hill overlooking frozen Ounasjoki River and it was all a waiting game after that. My toes were frozen and my chin started to hurt in the freezing cold. I was nearly at the tether of my patience. "Look to your left.....over the horizon". And silence ensued. Everyone's hearts leaped into their throats and adrenaline started pumping. I could feel that funny taste in my mouth and the tingling hot wave running down my spine even at -20C.

The pitch black sky was lit up in ghostly green. Initially a flicker, then the lights blazed across in gigantic waves breaking the silence of the dark night. I was completely transfixed. It felt as if the extra-terrestrials had just landed their UFO and the vibrant shades were emitted from their spaceship in perpetual motion, swaying, dancing, flowing, and changing colours.

Deeply engrossed in reflecting upon the first sighting of Aurora, I was walking nature's white carpet, ice lanterns casting patterned golden gleams on the star kissed snow. Almost out of nowhere loomed this gigantic white structure. I was stupefied. A few months ago this had been a rippling river, the water shimmering in the sunshine. Now it had transformed into the Arctic Snowhotel — a truly an out-of-this-world architecture that springs up each winter, 20km north of Rovaniemi. Around 20 million kg snow and 350,000 kg natural ice are used to build the spectacular Snowhotel which changes in shape, size and design every year. Covering 20,000 sq m there are thematic snow rooms, Ice

Continued on next page

Continued from previous page

Restaurant, Ice Bar, Ice Chapel, and a vast network of striking corridors full of spectacular snow and ice art.

Strangely it felt warm (-5 degrees) and inviting inside. The blue-yellow-orange glow of the lights offered comfort as I marvelled at the art work, especially the chapel, then had dinner from ice plates laid out on an ice table finishing off with an ice glass of steaming hot chocolate from the ice bar.

We strolled down to the frozen lake behind the Snowhotel where people had started gathering. There was a large Japanese group who had travelled across the world to see this spectacular phenomenon. As the minutes ticked away, the silence of the night started to seep into my blood and paralysed my brain, my pupils became dilated. "Will it happen tonight?" I could not stop trembling as I gazed at the distant tree-lined landscape.

Suddenly a shrill cry pierced through, moments later the entire Japanese group were hugging each other, screaming in delight and pointing excitedly upwards. The horizon was draped in an iridescent green, with shimmering blues and aquamarines and mellow yellows. One could not but be awe-struck as the lights danced with a whirling array of colours descending like a melting rainbow, across the sky.

Then, as quickly as they appeared, the enigmatic show of the mystic Northern lights vanished without a trace. Oh what a night! A night that would not be wiped away from my memory for ages to come.

Bankura – back to the roots

Sohini Datta Biswas

Pics: Sohini Datta Biswas

I have always wanted to see Bankura up close as it is the place where my ancestors came from. Many a days, I remember seeing Baba sigh and tell stories of how Dadu missed his land of red soil (picture right) and its people. So last time on our visit to Kolkata I took my father and 8-year-old daughter to Bankura. A trip down the memory lane for one and knowing our roots for the other. As for me, it was an experience that I will never forget. We were completely mesmerised by the natural beauty and won over by the hospitality of the locals as well as their artistic skills.

Our first stop was Bishnupur, a small town famous for temples and silk sarees. All the temples are dedicated to Lord Krishna, the most famous being the Raasmancha Temple (picture left) The architecture is unique and hasn't been seen in any other part of India.

The actual temple, a small chamber called the sanctum sanctorum, is situated within the heart of a maze of pillars and arches that are covered with handmade terracotta tiles. These artwork on the tiles proves the involvement of artisans from all over India. The top is a pyramid that also shows the possible involvement of Egyptian artisans in building this temple.

Next up was a visit to Darjipara or the street of the tailors. This is where the fabled Baluchari sarees originate. The silk sarees of Bishnupur have special appeal for saree collectors. I interviewed a National Award winnning weaver on the time spent on each saree he produces and his answer was "about a month and half".

We then visited a tiny village called Panchmura, home of the world famour terracotta horses and elephants. This charming gentleman (picture left) impressed us all with his smile and stories about the village while he effortlessly spun the wheel and produced the most amazing pottery.

Our final stop was Bikna, a tiny suburb just outside Bankura, home to the beautiful Dokra artifacts. It is the main occupation of the town, with even children casually making and breaking moulds, all in the name of play. Unlike eslewhere, in Bikna the women are the main artisans and they run the business too.

The striking colour of the soil in Bankura contributes to the clay art of the region. Everywhere you see there are terracotta or Dokra artefacts or just simple wall arts, making the place the most uniquely artistic that I have ever seen.

Pics: Moumita Chattopadhyay

Hakuna Matata in the kingdom of Mara

Moumita Chattopadhyay

At that moment,my soul whispered – 'If Heaven exists, it has to be here'……Fringed by slate grey rocks, the Talek river meandered away into eternity, its glittering waters catching the myriad hues of the setting sun. Against the canvas of a fiery orange tinged with violet stood a giraffe directly looking at us, his long neck etching a dark silhouette against the polychromatic sky. Sometimes the neck dipped, almost grazing the surface of the water and I would think he wanted a drink. Then he would straighten again without drinking and stare at us with those wide, innocent eyes.

Our Land Rover stood in the middle of Talek river with the giraffe on one side and the dull pink head of a massive hippo peeping out of the water on the other side. Here, at dusk, amidst the amniotic tranquillity of wilderness, Mother Nature's children coexisted in harmony, engraving for ever a memory of ethereal beauty in my heart.

And this was only our first evening at Maasai Mara! In an open jeep bumping our way through the wilds, we had already spotted half a century hippos piled up over one another on land and in water, wild buffaloes staring at space and munching away solemnly, overprotective mum elephants rushing to flank the baby after catching sight of our jeep, a group of young male cheetahs striding elegantly across the road taking no notice of ogling onlookers, an elusive leopard perched on a tree branch busy relishing a carcass.

Speaking about magnificence, can the royals be far behind? Preferring to hunt at night, it was relaxation hour for the monarch during daytime. Our driver had an uncanny aptitude of spotting them from far away and often we were the first people to approach the pride. He would unmistakably park the jeep at arm's length from the lions and we would uneasily have to sit in the silence listening to them crunching on a wildebeest's head or toby's ribs. They hardly bothered to cast even a sideway glance at us lesser mortals — their gleaming fangs, wavy manes and audacious demeanour speaking regal grandiosity. They were the undisputed King of the Jungles. Even the cubs seemed to be aware of this reality – while you marvel at their cuteness and long to caress, they retort with a rebuking glare.

And then, there was MIGRATION! Millions of wildebeests, zebras, gazelles walking, running, marching, stomping, romping, wandering, crossing the river, resting.....amid the mad rush was method, the method of the jungle! Queues – straight and serpentine, parallel and intersecting, moving and stationary, loomed and zoomed all around us. This was a celebration of life – the countless animals looking like a perpetual black cloud zipping up the horizon from one end to the other. This was a celebration of lifelessness – the countless killed in stampede while crossing river Mara, heaped atop one another with snarling hyenas and greedy vultures waiting for theim to perish.

In scale it was humongous, in beauty mesmerizing, in spirit indomitable. We did not have long lens cameras but I don't have any regret as the surreal moments are captivated in my heart forever. If heaven exists, it's here, at its raw best, in the Kingdom of Mara, in the land of hakuna matata (no worries).

Rainbow in Aleppo

Suvradeep Bhattacharjee

There is a big rainbow,
In my sweet Aleppo.
My streets are torn
By the bombs they dropped
One after the other
Until the Rain stopped
Until my pigeon started to scream
And I had a dream.

In the Centre of my city, Aleppo
There was this magical rainbow
Violet, Indigo
Blue, Green
Yellow, Orange, Red
Though my cousins have fled
But, I stopped at my window
To look at the Rainbow

Even the bombing stopped
The curfew dropped
And the fighter pilots took a pause
To look at what's lost

I have one wish
I wish
There would always be a Rainbow
In every sweet Aleppo.

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To be united with Almighty

Mousumi Chakraborty

Who is Almighty? Hardly I know,
Only can see the darkness and glow —
Of sorrow and joy in this universe,
That comes as blessings or as curse.

I can find the poor and weak,
Wretched beggars, the rich all seek
Love, care and peace in life,
Find in them the "God" in strife.

With pain, I close my eyes and ask Divine
"How I unite with you? — Oh God of Mine"
Answer comes in —
"Searching the Soul and Serving the Needy
To be strong in Mind, Soul and Body".

My Bong way of learning hangul mal (Korean language)

Tanima Dhar

Five years ago, on a sultry summer morning, when I landed in Incheon Airport, in Seoul, I was a little more than worried: I had left my home, my secure job to accompany my husband to a destination that didn't seem quiet alluring.

They asked me "why" at the immigration counter; I replied "because my husband is working with Samsung" they smiled and stamped "welcome".

Accompaning the husband, raising the kid, huh was that the agenda for the next few years then? I sighed as I pulled the luggage and strove to drag my soul along as well: she is a born rebel.

"I refuse" she screamed silently, and I knew she did, in these claustrophobic streets hemmed in by high rises and CCTV everywhere watching your every move like Sherlock Holmes. I tried to make peace, "May be Suwon is different. Seoul is the capital."

"Why dont you ask?"

So in a very desi style I tried to initiate some dialogue with the cabbie. When he didn't respond even after 5mins of blabbering, my husband explained, "He dosen't understand English and that is the problem we need to cope or combat." And thus our journey in South Korea begun on a most unwelcoming note.

The very first day, only a few hours after arriving at our destination we were trying to locate a place where food looked familiar. After quiet a search we found Mr MacDonald waving at us. Long live MacD we cheered.

But....what to order? Every single menu was in Korean and no one spoke a word of English! Our local phones were yet to be activated so even mighty Google couln't come to the rescue with pictures and translations. What if we ask for chicken burger and get dog patti served instead!

Even thinking about it gave me goosebumps...closing my eyes I could only see my sister-in-law's cute little poodle Fluffy trapped between two gigantic burger buns and everytime it tried to escape it trips on the sauce! No, I couldn't risk that happening!

So shameless as always, I sallied forth to save my family from a possible disaster and distress. At the counter I furiously flapped my hands like wings at the saleman and shouted kukru ku ku ....and bingo! He understood. Probably I wasn't the not the only one!

By the third day we were talking in Bangla at the grocery store and the salesmen were trying to help in native Korean. Our acting skills got better with every passing day .

By the end of the first month Samsung took the initiative to send me a private tutor to teach me Korean — or Hangul Mal — and I was an eager student. I left no opportunity to practice. Every time I took the bus I would request the driver "Ajousi chuptha?" and every time he would give me a vague look. Only after a few days into my lessons I realised I was asking the driver to "please pick me up" when I should have been saying "Ajousi nerejuseyo (please drop me at a particular stop)"

Soon I started falling in love with the place,the people and their amazing hospitality. I would often travel intercity, on my own, and made friends where ever I went and tried to converse as much as I can with the locals.

My desi Bong self was ecstatic the day I discovered this fresh fish market and I could not resist a 3kg rohu: "Ajuma sangsangnim challajuseyo," I told the fishmonger lady.

The poor old women burst out laughing: Aigo oni sengson?

Sengson in Korean is fish but what I said instead is "Can you kindly chop my sangsangnim (teacher) into pieces!"

Learning a new language is intriguing, comitting mistakes was fun.

It wasn't only us who were learning Korean but with the raising number of Indians been outsourced by Samsung, the local farmers were also keen to know what we eat and thus procure for us vegiges like cauliflower and coriander once a month.We all had our favourite vendor who would keep aside or call us whenever he got our favourite produce.

During one of my strolls in the weekly market I was amazed at how mine was calling me aloud: "Tanya, Tanya" I hadn't expected him to know my name. So with the biggest possiblegrin I went up to him to correct and teach how to pronounce my name: "Tanya no,Tanima. " He replied waving a bunch of corriander: "Dhaniya, dhaniya!"

After four years in Korea, I have picked up very few bits of vocabulary but have gathered memories of a lifetime of the most amazing, hospitable country I have ever travelled in.

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WannaCry attack

Trijit Das, Age 13

The WannaCry ransomware attack was a worldwide cyber attack by the WannaCry ransomware cryptoworm that affected over 150 countries. It began on Friday 12th May and within a day infected over 230,000 computers, targeting computers running Microsoft's Windows operating system, especially Windows 7. The attackers encrypted data on the infected computers and demanded ransom to restore the data, giving victims only a few days to pay up.

Unsupported versions of Windows, which are at a bigger risk, are also being helped using an emergency security patch for the platforms. The makers of the ransomware created their own currency type called bitcoin, meaning that a certain amount of money is equivalent to 1 bitcoin. Experts have advised against paying the ransom since there have been no reports of people getting their data back even after the payment.

The sea

Eshaan Sikdar, Age 11

I am strong,
I'm talented and the
Clouds gives me a Loud clap!
Yet people don't care.

I am filled with treasures, beyond your reach.
I am a puppet,
Controlled by the moon!
I wash away your very sorrow.

When I rage, I send Tsunami's your way.
I tickle beings with my blue fingers;
I shuffle your land.
I could easily wrap you up and throw you away.

Three days of fun

Smera Sachin, Age 10

Durga
puja to me
is a festival, we
enjoy together and have fun
with friends.

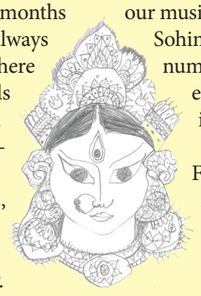
We dance
and sing all day
long, play around until
we all feel tired and is time to
go home.

The food
is so yummy
we all stuff ourselves with
it, and all enjoy a second
helping.

We make
so many friends
at Durga puja and
when it is time to go it is
so sad.

My first Puja in Cambridge

Tara Paul, Age 10



I was new to the city and Durga Puja was just a few months away. Whenever I thought about Durga Puja I always remembered South Korea, and our very own Puja there — how much fun I used to have there, what my friends and got up to — and miss every single thing about it. Little did I know then there were Durga Puja celebrations in Cambridge as well!

One day while returning from my dance class, Mamma asked me if I would like to participate in a musical show. "But where do you want me to perform?" I asked: She kept it a secret until the next day. And it made me even more curious.

The next day we drove to the Ross Street Community Centre and as Mamma was parking I spotted through the window a bunch of kids of my age carrying various musical instruments going into the centre.

And thus I got introduced to Tanisha, Olie, Joshee, and was overwhelmed to meet Smera whom I already knew! I also met Radha mashi and Nandan jethu, who guided us in our musical performances for the upcoming Durga Puja, Sohini mashi and Sonela mashi taught us the dance numbers. It felt like we all are part of one big family. I enjoyed myself so much — even more than I did in Korea. We all played like brothers and sisters!

From then on, every week, I looked forward to Friday when I would join the rest for rehearsals. Durga Puja came up very soon. Jhinook didi and Teesta didi, helped us get ready for the performances.

That year the Puja was held at my school (Bewick Bridge Primary School) over a weekend in October. I must say it was the BEST Puja I have celebrated.

Pic: Tara Paul

Aranyer din ratri

Projjol Rudra, Age 8

Pic: Pallab Rudra

(above) An elephant roams among the trees at the Gorumara forest; (left) I rode in a bullock cart with my grandfathers

This time when I went to Kolkata, my parents took me to the North of Bengal, to a forest at the base of the Himalayas. They said "We are going for aranyer din ratri." All my family including my four grandparents travelled together. It was so exciting to be with my entire family. I felt I was up in the moon.

We went by overnight train to Siliguri, the gateway to the forests. Next morning we took a big van to Gorumara forest. On the way, we stopped by the Murti river and splashed about for a while. It was heaps of fun. Then we carried on to our destination.

At the forest, we stayed in two bamboo cottages built on stilts so that animals and snakes couldn't reach us. At night the forest turned pitch black with hundreds of fireflies lighting up the path through the thick bushes. I heard some strange noises all around and although I couldn't recognise them, Daddy told me they were frogs and crickets. For dinner I had parota with egg curry, which was too spicy for me.

The next day we rode in a bullock cart to a watch tower, a tall light-house-like structure, looking out deep into the jungle. I was very excited. I saw two elephants crossing the Murti river which flows through the forest. I saw another elephant eating leaves from the tall trees. There were two peacocks and a neelkanth bird playing in the long grass and some bisons drinking water in the river. I looked and looked and looked but there were no rhinos. I felt tired and sleepy. All the others kept on watching.

We took the bullock cart back through the jungle to our eco-village where I played with the wild goats. They especially enjoyed eating biscuits out of my hand. Mummy was very scared of the cheerful goats, but I had great fun. I even made a few friends.

Later, we walked down to the beautiful Chukchuki Lake surrounded by quiet woods. I water was so clear I could see right down to the weeds. We took a boat and the clear water created magical reflections of the trees. I even spotted some fish playing around. How exciting it was, I can't describe in words.

The trip is now over and I am back home but I will treasure this wonderful memory forever.

Fun in the sun

Shopno Bhowmick, Age 9

Pic: Shopno Bhowmick

Super hot and steamy!
Unbelievably fun!
Mega awesome!
Mum, Dad, my sister and me having fun!
Entertaning goodness!
Running up a mountain in Wales!

Having fun in the sun!
On an adventure!
Lots of time together!
Inside a train going to places!
Dad likes being with his friends!
Also having good times always!
Yummy food to eat!
Sometimes at home together with family!

Hope you had a happy summer too.

A visit to the Victoria Falls

Ritisha Baidyaray, Age 10

Still sometimes I dream that I can hear the rebellious waters of the majestic Victoria Falls thundering down. And I wish with all my heart that I could go back once more to the place that has captivated me forever. But time doesn't stop to sympathise with the yearnings of anyone! So I have to remain contended with reminiscing every single moment of that ethereal experience when I saw the mighty falls for the first time; every single moment my heart beat rhythmically with the music of the water.

To begin with, I rode in a helicopter for the first time in my life, my spirits soaring as I couldn't wait to catch a glimpse of the colossal Victoria Falls. We flew high and low, tilting from left to right and going at extreme angles in the air, getting views from every possible direction. We could see right down the gorges where people were rafting. We even saw a rainbow, shimmering through the playful waters.

Then we went on a Victoria Falls walking tour. There were 16 view points on the Zimbabwe side. My first impression of the falls was a wall of milky white water plunging deep down into the gorges with a thunderous noise! The gorges were so deep that I couldn't make out where the water was disappearing but it seemed like a monster was hiding in the depths of Mother Nature and engulfing the furore. In the distant gorges a mystic blanket smothered the view.

The falls was so near that I could feel its shower of mist, yet the deep gorges seemed so far beyond our reach; the turbulent waters so imposing yet so intangible; its awe inspiring existence so forceful, yet so sublime! I was mesmerised and this feeling only intensified at each viewpoint as we explored the waterfall from different angles.

Next up was a Victoria Falls Bridge Tour. So after watching a short performance of the building of the bridge, we clipped on our harnesses and went under the bridge! It was a kind of thrill I had never had felt before: it felt amazing. To top it all, as we moved along the bridge, we witnessed a breath-taking view of the Zambezi river below gushing through the cliffs!

One particular scene keeps playing in my head like a film that is played over and over again: Me, making my way to the edge of a viewpoint, burying my head lovingly into my mother's and father's ponchos and clasping their hands, gazing and drinking in the waterfall's beauty; watching the water plunge into the rocky depths of the gorge; feeling the spray of the waterfall caress my face before dripping down; the mist rising tall and strong and floating over our heads; staring at the waterfall flaunt its pearl-white crests ostentatiously!

Even though the visit is long over, it doesn't mean I can't relive the experience over and over again. And I will, for as long as my soul lives on.

Pic: Rudraprasad Baidyaray

The Zambezi river tumbles as the mighty Victoria Falls. (above) At the start of the tour.

What school means to me

Oishani Goswami, Age 11

Playing in the field in summer, secret handshakes, memorising the words for a surprise song, being chosen for a maths challenge, all of these memories are a part of why I love my school.

Walking through the rusty school gates each morning, my heart fills with warmth at the thought of meeting my lovely and caring teachers and friends and I look forward to learning and discovering a host of new things. Be it learning how to construct a Roman catapult or learning about the Victorians or making a 3D contour model during Earth-Matters, there is always something new to try out. Not to forget all the extra-curricular things that we do alongside — of all the big-sings and big-draws; or the days at swimming and cricket; or simply the days of running around the fields that seem to stretch out for miles and blend with the churchyard and cricket fields beyond.

The best thing about my school is that we are a community. At ours, the oldest and the youngest of the 90-odd students learn to work with each other and create friendships. Thus, when it came to our annual school play, all the year groups pitched in and Superstan (a spin on Superman) was not only a huge success but also great fun for everyone along the way.

Some days during the long summer holiday, I wish I were back at school and with my friends.

And last but not the least, there are my fantastic friends whom I can trust and feel comfortable around. They care for me and are always there for me. We are as close as sisters and share an unbreakable bond. They make me who I am and much more.

Babraham Primary is like a big tree. The teachers are the roots, keeping us steady and giving us a good start in life. The trunk and the branches with the blossoming new leaves are the students, swaying under the gentle guidance of the wind that surrounds us — our parents.

On some days in the summer holidays I almost wish I were back at school, with my friends, chattering away while working in class or playing outside... So while I enjoyed the long and lazy days at home, I'm glad school has reopened. Here's looking forward to another fun-filled year!

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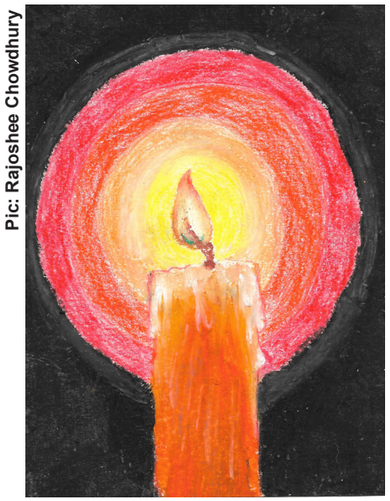
Pic: Rajoshee Chowdhury



Life is a candle

Rajoshee Chowdhury

Age: 11

Life is a candle,
It glows so bright,
The dark cannot reach it,
For when it is alight,
It is a truly wonderful sight…

Life is a candle,
At times it may flicker,
And when it does,
Problems can appear quicker,
Life becomes trickier…

Life is a candle,
When it's light shines brighter,
Happiness can also occur,
To balance life out a bit more,
We must cry and have laughter…

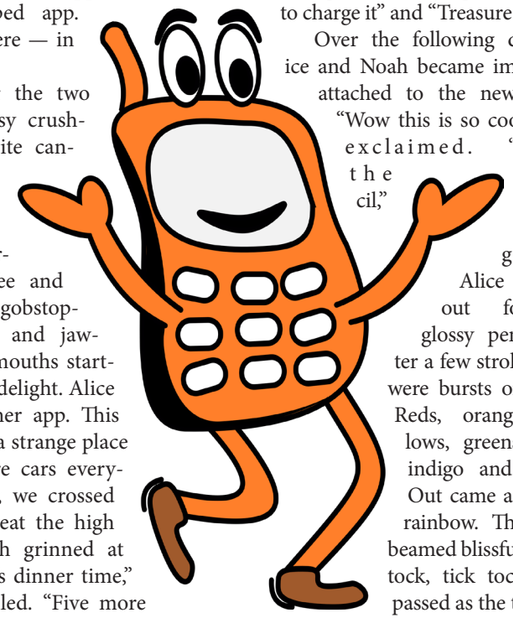
Life is a candle,
It must be blown out,
When a candle becomes dimmer,
Short and stout,
It is blown out…
Life is a candle,
It glows so bright,
The dark cannot reach it,
For when it is alight,
It is a truly wonderful sight.

When the alarm bells rang

Rai Bhattacharjee, Age 12

Ow, Ow, Ouch, Stop pulling me!" I cried but they couldn't hear. "It's my turn to play," Alice said. "No it's mine!" demanded Noah. Alice sighed and snatched me up before Noah could react. She typed in the passcode. A whole world of apps appeared. In a flash we were off, travelling on a jetpack, collecting coins and completing exciting missions. No sooner had we achieved our aim, it was Noah's turn. He pressed my home button and tapped on the candy shaped app. And there we were — in Candyland.

Moments later the two of them got busy crushing their favourite candies by completing puzzles. Alice crushed liquorice, butterscotch and toffee and Noah crushed gobstoppers, gumdrops and jawbreakers. Their mouths started to water with delight. Alice tapped on another app. This time we were in a strange place where there were cars everywhere. Excitedly, we crossed the roads and beat the high score! They both grinned at me. "Children it's dinner time," their mother called. "Five more minutes," insisted Noah. "Please," cried Alice. Mother gave them a look. They sighed and left the room. I was left alone again like every evening; but they always came back.



Thud thud thud. I was awoken by footsteps. "Shh" whispered Alice. "We'll just play one game and then go to bed," Noah hissed back. . A small hand reached out and tried to grab me. I slipped. My face shattered into tiny pieces. My head spun. The room started to blur. Everything turned pitch black…

Chit chat, chatter. I could hear voices from another room. "I think it's time we get a new one," a voice suggested. "I agree, it would be a great birthday surprise for the kids," another voice replied.

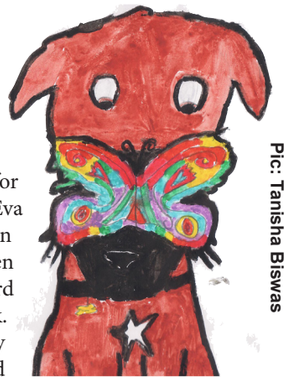
Crumpling, rustling and out came another one of me, but far more advanced. It had a multi-touch screen, vivid retina display, 10 hours of battery life, a pencil enabling you to create a range of artistic effects and a gorgeous rose gold back. Everything about it seemed special. I could hear eager voices saying "Don't forget to charge it" and "Treasure it well".

Over the following days Alice and Noah became immensely attached to the new object. "Wow this is so cool," Alice exclaimed. "Let's try the pencil," Noah suggested. Alice reached out for the glossy pencil. After a few strokes there were bursts of colour. Reds, oranges, yellows, greens, blues, indigo and violets. Out came a magical rainbow. They both beamed blissfully. Tick tock, tick tock. Time passed as the two children played with this entertaining item. I waited hoping that someday they'd play with me again. I missed our adventures, travels and laughter. I was forgotten. I felt that I was disappearing slowly, piece by piece.

Beep beep beep. The alarm went off. I felt fine, my face was smooth again. I looked across the room and saw Noah and Alice rushing towards me. I realised that was just a dream, a bad dream after all.

Madness in Madagascar

Tanisha Biswas, Age 9



Pic: Tanisha Biswas

No Zeus is not coming!" Mum said sternly. "But Mum," whined Tanisha and Eva. "No means no," replied Mum in that tone mothers use which you can't argue with. "Well then we'll never talk to you again!" Mum decided she had to take Zeus with them. "Fine! We'll take him with us." With that, and with only two hours of packing, they were on the plane to Madagascar.

Eva, Tanisha, Mum and Zeus were in their seats when the announcer announced, "Please fasten your seatbelts. We will be landing in 15 minutes." The plane landed bumpily on the tarmac and as soon as it had docked at terminal and the family raced out.

They set up a small camp near a little lake with fresh water. The family set out for a bit of exploring, through the dense forests teeming with creepy crawlies. Tanisha and Eva had fun stroking baby lemurs and picking pretty flowers. The pink and red flowers everywhere made the jungle look like it had been laid with a beautiful carpet. The flora and fauna truly magnificent.

After a hour or two of exploring, Mum, Eva and Tanisha made their way back to the camp when it struck Tanisha that Zeus hadn't made any noise in quite a while. Which was strange since Zeus liked nothing more than to run wild , barking at the top of his voice whenever let off his leash. Looking around, Tanisha realised that it was so quiet because Zeus was missing! She whispered to Eva in panic and they ran off shouting, "Zeus, where are you?"

Meanwhile, Zeus was having a little adventure of his own. He had wandered off and found himself a nice sunny spot along the beach. He stretched out, just chilling and loving the beautiful butterflies sitting on his nose. His big ears pricked up at Tanisha's voice in the distance and he was just about to bark in happiness when a large, red crab crept up to him and bit him on his tail! With a loud yelp he jumped up, and ran straight into Eva. "There you are Zeus! We've been looking everywhere for you!" Eva sighed in relief. Then they heard a shriek. They turned around to see Tanisha was sinking in quicksand.

In his doggy mind, Zeus thought quickly. Out of the corners of his soft, brown eyes he spotted a big vine. He grabbed it in his teeth and passed it to Eva. Together they pulled Tanisha out of the quicksand.

They all walked quietly and safely back to the camp. They told Mum about their adventures and, grateful that they were all safe, she let them have as many the s'mores as they could!

The next few days went by happily and then they went home. But Eva and Tanisha never argued about Zeus coming on holidays again.

Journey alone

Mahi Deb, Age 11

Pic: Mahi Deb

It is said that travelling leaves you speechless, and then turns you into a storyteller. These are the words of travellers who have travelled around the world and this is what travelling means to me.

Usually I travel with my parents and we have visited countries like Egypt, Morocco, and Switzerland. Last summer we went on a road trip of 6,000 miles across 13 countries in Europe. On this trip I saw a chocolate factory in Belgium and the colossal castle of Prague. But, a few weeks ago, for the first time I was given an opportunity to travel abroad on a school trip and I took it!

This trip to Salamanca, in Spain, was a language trip where we had lessons with actual Spanish people! The school where we studied was called Colegio Delbes and it added a more cultural and creative feel to the lessons.

There are two beautiful cathedrals in Salamanca, one ancient and the other "new" — though even the "new" one is centuries old! Both were damaged in the great Lisbon earthquake of 1755, and the damage is still visible.

Our days began early with an energetic breakfast, followed by four hours of Spanish lessons. We would then have lunch and siesta. My favourite lunch was the paella, made with chicken and amazing seafood cooked with fragrant yellow rice. In the evenings we would do an activity and then have dinner. Hands down, my favourite activity was the treasure hunt, partially because we won but, also because we got to explore a lot of the city.

This trip was a lifetime experience for me. I would urge all parents to allow their children to travel abroad by themselves at some point because it would help them become independent.

Tara Bhowmick, Age 5

Rijoy Goswami, Age 6

Abhigyan Bhattacharya, Age 6

IT'S TIME FOR COLOURS!!!

Aditi Arvind, Age 5

Anisha Arvind, Age 6

Aniruddho Acharjee, Age 6

অভিজ্ঞতা

রঞ্জু বক্সী

আজ থেকে বছর তেইশ আগের অভিজ্ঞতা আমার, কলকাতাতে। বৈশাখ মাস, ছোটভাইয়ের বিয়ে ঠিক হয়েছে। মাবাবার একান্ত ইচ্ছে বিয়েতে আমার উপস্থিতি। কোলকাতা যেতে আমার সবসময় ই ভাল লাগে- তার উপর ভাইয়ের বিয়ে। গরমের কথা ভেবে একটু দ্বিধা হচ্ছিল বটে!! যাইহোক শেষ পর্য্যন্ত যাওয়াই ঠিক করলাম। দমদম পৌঁছে দেখি - বাড়ী থেকে তখনো কেউ এসে পৌঁছোয়নি আমাকে নিতে - very unusual, আমার কাছে কোন টাকাও ছিলনা যে এয়ারপোর্ট'র পে-ফোন থেকে ফোন করব। আমি ভাবছি - কেন কেউ আমাকে এখনও নিতে আসেনি !! তখন হঠাৎ , অন্যান্য যাত্রীদের মধ্যে দাঁড়িয়ে থাকা এক যুবক আমাকে বলল - এয়ারপোর্টের ফোন আউট অফ অর্ডার , বাইরে বাঁ ধারে একটু গিয়ে একটা পাবলিক ফোন আছে, চলুন আমি দেখিয়ে দিচ্ছি - এই নিন একটাকা। আমি বাইরে যেতে চাইনি। ঠিক সেই সময়ই এক যাত্রী এয়ারপোর্টের ফোন থেকে ফোন করাতে বুঝেছিলাম যুবকটি মিথ্যা বলে আমাকে বাইরে নিয়ে যেতে চেয়েছিল। যুবকটি তখন আমাকে ভাল এক্সচেঞ্জ রেট দেবে পাউণ্ড আর ডলারে - এইসব বলতে লাগল।

ইতিমধ্যে ভাই এসে গেছে আমাকে নিতে। সে দিন কোলকাতায় ধর্মঘট ডেকেছিল, তাই আসতে দেরী। যুবকটি তখন ভাইকেও ভাল এক্সচেঞ্জ রেট দিয়ে পাউণ্ড/ ডলার কেনার কথা বলতে লাগল। ফিরে আসার আগের শুক্রবার সকাল ১১টার সময় দক্ষিণ কলকাতার এক ব্যাঙ্কের দোতলায় ফরেন কারেন্সি সেকশনে গিয়ে দেখি টেবিলে কেউ নেই। অন্যান্য টেবিলে কয়েকজন নিজেদের মধ্যে কথা বলছেন ক্রিকেট নিয়ে , কাছেই একজন দাঁড়িয়ে দেশলাই কাঠি দিয়ে দাঁত খুঁটে যাচ্ছেন। কারুর কোন গ্রাহ্যই নেই, আমি যে দাঁড়িয়ে আছি। কয়েক মিনিট পরে দাঁত খোঁটা শেষ করে লোকটি ডেস্কে ফিরে এসে আমাকে প্রশ্ন করলেন - " আপনার কি চাই?"। ট্রাভেলার্স চেক ভাঙ্গানোর কথা বলাতে উনি বললেন -" আজকে কেন এসেছেন ? আজ হবে না, আগামী বুধবার আসবেন।" কারন জানতে চাইলে উনি বললেন " জানেন না ? আজ থেকে ইন্ডিয়া - পাকিস্তান টেস্ট ম্যাচ শুরু ! যারা ট্রাভেলার্স চেক ক্যাশ করেন , তাঁরা আসেননি।" আগামী সপ্তাহে ফিরে যাচ্ছি বলাতে সেই একই উত্তর " বললাম তও আজ হবে না -" বলেই আবার ক্রিকেট নিয়ে আলোচনা নিজেদের মধ্যে।

তখন বাধ্য হয়ে ড্রাইভারকে পার্ক স্ট্রীটের একটা ব্যাঙ্কে নিয়ে যেতে বলি। ড্রাইভার আমাকে ব্যাঙ্কের সামনে নামিয়ে দিয়ে বলল -" এখানে পার্ক করতে পারবো না, রাস্তার ওপারে পার্ক করছি। কাজ হয়ে গেলে চলে আসবেন। রাস্তার ওপারে দেখি শত শত গাড়ী পার্ক করা - সব-ই প্রায় অ্যামবাসাডর ।

এই ব্যাঙ্কের একতলাতে ই ট্রাভেলার্স চেক ভাঙ্গানো যাবে। T.C Section এ এগিয়ে দেখি বিমান বন্দরের সেই যুবকটিও দাঁড়িয়ে আছে। আমি খুব চেষ্টা করছি যাতে eye contact না হয়।

অল্প সময়ের মধ্যেই আমার কাজ হয়ে গেছে। গেটের কাছে এসে দেখি ঐ যুবকটি সেখানে ঘোরাঘুরি করছে। আমার তখন একটু ভয় লাগতে শুরু করেছে। অত টাকা নিয়ে রাস্তা পার হয়ে গাড়িতে যাওয়ার সাহস হচ্ছিল না , যুবকটিকে ওখানে দেখার পর। তাই ব্যাঙ্কের দারোয়ানকে গাড়ীর নম্বর দিয়ে অনুরোধ করলাম যদি ওপারে গিয়ে ড্রাইভারকে ব্যাঙ্কের সামনে আসতে বলে। ব্যাঙ্কের বাইরে সিঁড়িতে একটি বছর ২২/২৩ এর ছেলে বসে ছিল - গাইয়ে ছেঁড়া জামাকাপড়, পায়ে নেই জুতো, কদিন বোধহয় স্নানও হয়নি। চরম দারিদ্র্যের লক্ষণ সারা অঙ্গে। দারোয়ান তাকে গাড়ীর নম্বর দিয়ে ড্রাইভারকে ব্যাঙ্কের সামনে গাড়ী নিয়ে আসতে বলার জন্য পাঠাল। কয়েক মিনিটের মধ্যেই ড্রাইভার গাড়ী নিয়ে উপস্থিত।

আমি ছেলেটিকে অল্প কিছু টাকা দিতে গিয়েছিলাম "to show my gratitude", সে কিছুতেই নেবেনা। কয়েকবার অনুরোধ করা সত্ত্বেও সে হাতজোড় করে হাসি মুখে মাথা নাড়তে লাগলো - সে টাকা নেবে না। শেষে সিঁড়ি থেকে উঠে হাঁটতে শুরু করল।

আমি আজও লজ্জিত যে সামান্য টাকা দিয়ে ওর মানবিকতাকে আমি অপমান করতে চেয়েছিলাম ! এত বছর পরে মাঝে মাঝেই ঐ ঘটনার কথা আমার মনে হয়, আমি আজও কৃতজ্ঞ সেই উদারহৃদয়, নিঃস্বার্থপর ছেলেটির কাছে।

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প্র: ভারতে সংগঠিত ভাবে শিল্প চর্চা কবে থেকে শুরু হল, সেটা একটু বলুন না।

উঃ সেভাবে দেখতে গেলে আর্ট স্কুল তৈরির ব্যাপারটা ইংরেজ আমলেই পাওয়া যায়। নানা জায়গায় স্কুল তৈরি হয়, কলকাতা থেকে লাহোর অবধি, কিন্তু ইংরেজরা আসলে এগুলো করেছিল ততটা শিল্পচর্চার জন্য নয়, যতটা ড্রাফটসম্যান তৈরি করার জন্য। আমাদের দেশে তার বহু যুগ আগে থেকে শিল্প চর্চার ভালো রকম ইতিহাস কিন্তু ছিল। অজন্তা-ইলোরার কথাই ধরুন। কি অদ্ভুত সব কাজ, যেমন টেকনিক, তেমন গর্জাস। তবে পরবর্তী কালে এই শিল্প গুলো হারিয়ে যায়। তার অনেক কারণ ছিল, রাজনৈতিক অস্থিরতা একটা বড় কারন ।

প্র: অজন্তা নিয়ে তো আপনি দীর্ঘদিন কাজ করেছেন, তাই না ?

উঃ হ্যাঁ , সাত বছর ধরে আমি অজন্তায় ছবি কপি করেছি। আরকিওলজিকাল সার্ভের কাজ। গুহার মধ্যে আলো নিয়ে কাজ করতে হত। সে অদ্ভুত অভিজ্ঞতা। অজন্তার ছবির টেকনিক নিয়ে আমার লেখা বইও আছে। সেই সময়ের অভিজ্ঞতা থেকেই লেখা।

প্র: অজন্তার পর প্রধান শিল্প শৈলী বলতে ...

উঃ সে তো অনেক, মুঘল , রাজপুত, কাঙরা, কোটা, মারোয়া ... অনেক আছে... আধুনিককালে আমাদের অবন ঠাকুর যখন আর্ট কলেজে ভাইস প্রিন্সিপাল হলেন, উনি একটা নতুন রাস্তা দেখালেন... এই সব আলাদা আলাদা শিল্প কে মিশিয়ে একটা অন্যরকম ঘরানা তৈরি করলেন, তৈরি হল বেঙ্গল স্কুল অফ আর্ট। এর মধ্যে মুঘল, রাজপুত, মিনিয়েচার পেন্টিং ছাড়া মিশেছিল জাপানী ধারা, ওয়াশের কাজ এই সব। সেই সময়টা ছিল এদেশে শিল্পের সুবর্ণ যুগ। বিখ্যাত সব শিল্পীরা তখন কাজ করছেন, নন্দলাল বোস, অসিত হালদার, শৈলজানন্দ এঁরা সব ছিলেন। এঁরা সব সারা ভারতে নানা আর্ট স্কুলে ছড়িয়ে পড়লেন। এর মধ্যে নন্দলাল বোস কিন্তু নিজের একটা ঘরানা তৈরি করলেন। উনি অবনীন্দ্রনাথের ঠিক অনুসারী হলেন না। শান্তিনিকেতনের প্রকৃতির মধ্যে গিয়ে পড়ে তিনি একটা নিজস্ব স্টাইলে কাজ শুরু করলেন। গোয়াস দিয়ে তিনি টাচ পেন্টিং আরম্ভ করলেন। তাঁর ছাত্রদের মধ্যে সব নামকরা শিল্পীদের আমরা পেলাম - যেমন রামকিঙ্কর বেজ, বিনোদবিহারী মুখোপাধ্যায়, কে.জে সুব্রমানিয়াম - এই যে একটা শিল্প আন্দোলন হল, তার ধারাটা চলতেই থাকল। আরও নানারকম ব্যাপার আসতে থাকল, ইম্প্রেশনিজম, পোস্ট ইম্প্রেশনিজম, অ্যাবস্ট্রাকশন , সুররিয়ালিসম এইসব এলো। দুনিয়া অনেক ছোট হয়ে গেল। বিদেশ আর এদেশের মধ্যে অনেক মেলামেশা হতে থাকলো। এখন ধরুন আমাদের এখানে যা কাজ হয় তার সঙ্গে পৃথিবীর অন্যান্য জায়গার কাজের অনেক মিশ্রণ হয়। এখানে এখন ইন্সটালেশন আর্ট হচ্ছে, ভিডিও আর্ট হচ্ছে, এসব কত কিছু আমরা পাচ্ছি। এটা একটা ধারাবাহিক শিল্প আন্দোলনের ফল

প: এই আন্দোলনের প্রধান হোতা কি অবনীন্দ্রনাথ ?

উঃ হ্যাঁ, তাই বলা যায়। গগনেন্দ্রনাথ ও আছেন।

প্রঃ আর রবীন্দ্রনাথ ?

উঃ দেখুন উনি কোন স্কুলের নন, ওনার একটা সম্পূর্ন নিজস্ব ধারা। তবে প্রথম দিকে লোকে সেটা খুব একটা নেয় নি। বিদেশে সমাদৃত হবার পর এদেশেও লোকে ওনার ছবির কদর করতে শুরু করে। রবীন্দ্রনাথ কে আমি অতি আধুনিক একজন শিল্পী মনে করি।

প্রঃ আপনার নিজের সম্বন্ধে যদি দু এক কথা বলেন।

উঃ আমি আর কি বলব। আমার জন্ম ময়মনসিংহের জামালপুরে। রিফুজি হয়ে এদেশে আসি ১৯৫০ সালে। খুব কষ্টে কেটেছে। আর্ট কলেজে ভর্তি হয়েছিলাম। তারপর থেকে ছবি এঁকে যাচ্ছি।

প্রঃ আপনার ছবি আঁকার বিষয়ে বাড়ি থেকে কখন কোন বাধা পাননি ?

উঃ সে বিষয়ে আমার ভাগ্য ভালোই ছিল। আমাকে বাড়ি থেকে কোন বাধা দেওয়া হয় নি। মনের তাগিদে ছবি আঁকতে শুরু করি, ওটা ছাড়া আর কিছু করার কথা কোনদিন ভাবিনি। ওটা ছিল নেশা। পরে ওটাই আমার জীবিকা হয়ে গেল। ছবির ধরনও বদলেছে আমার ধীরে ধীরে। মনের চোখে যা দেখি সেটাই আঁকি। সেটা রিয়ালিস্টিক হল কিনা সেটা বড় কথা নয়, মনের ভাব টা বার করে আনতে পারলাম কিনা সেটাই আসল। এই ভাবেই ছবি এঁকে যাচ্ছি সারা জীবন।

প্রঃ এইভাবেই আপনি ছবি এঁকে চলুন আরও অনেকদিন, এটাই আমরা সবাই চাই। অনেক কিছু জানতে পারলাম আপনার সঙ্গে কথা বলে। অনেক ধন্যবাদ।

A fishy fellow

In the few years since it opened, Fish Fish in Kolkata has become a familiar name among people looking for simple homecooked fare and old, forgotten tastes. Tanima Dhar catches up with chef Debashish Kundu,the man behind this success story.

Q: Children in most Bengali households are raised with the stereotypical dream of becoming an engineer, doctor or MBA. What made you want to become a chef?

A: I too followed the expected route to graduation and even cleared the MBA entrance. But I had always wanted to be a fashion designer. However, I didn't quiet have the background to support that dream. So I followed some friends and ended up at the Indian Institute of Hotel Mangement with a "managerial" dream. Soon, I realised hotel management was very different from what I had thought. By this time I was already taking on commissions for food styling. And who better understands food than a chef!

Q: Who is your favourite cook?

A: My ma. We are refugees from Bangladesh…Bangal, you know. We never waste anything in the kitchen and can turn the most humble of vegetables into a delicacy. Ma's chitoler muitha and paturi are to die for.

Q: Talking of roots, are there any extinct dishes that you promote at Fish Fish?

A: Yes we do. Fish Fish is a fishy affair through and through (laughs). Our aim here is to promote any kind of food cooked with fish but "fusion" is strictly banned as I believe in authenticity and originality.

There are quite a few recipes we are trying to preserve, even resurrect. One such is padmo fuler kuri bata ilish. Lotus flowers and hilsa are abundant in Bangladesh, and this dish was typically cooked by the fishermen. The recipe is simple: we make a paste of lotus seeds, posto (poppy), green chillis and cook the fish in it with mustard oil.

We also make pora ilish (burnt hilsa).Before refrigerators, people used to preserve their hilsha by marinating them in salt and turmeric and placing them by the clay oven. Eventually it would get a little burnt, thus the name. It tastes divine with piping hot rice. We also make chingri macher banshpatar paturi — the prawn is wrapped in bamboo leaves with spices and stacked inside green bamboo shoots and baked until the bamboo cracks.

Q: Do you serve meat as well at Fish Fish?

A: Fish Fish is all about fish, and only fish. We have another chain 'Alibaba' for Mughlai cuisine.

Keema Kofta Curry

Mutton mince 250g; 2 fat garlic cloves; half inch ginger; 1 onion; about 4-5 almonds, soaked in water and peeled; 2 slices of bread, sides cut; 1 potato, boiled; ½ cup of besan; 2 tsp of ground red pepper; 2 tsp of ground coriander; 1 tsp of ground cumin; 1 tsp of black pepper powder; 2 tsp of garam masala; 1 tsp of cumin seeds; half cup of yogurt; half cup of cooking oil to fry the kofta

Making the koftas

– In a mixer-grinder make a smooth paste of onion, ginger & garlic.

– On a medium low flame stir-fry the keema till they change colour. Add about half a tsp of lemon juice and stir it well. Take the mince out in a big mixing bowl. Let cool a little bit.

– Add boiled potato, bread slices and besan.Adjust the amount of besan or bread slices.

– Add the onion/ginger/garlic paste.

– Add all the dry grounded masala and half cup of yogurt.

– in a deep bottom pan, add oil, and let it heat up well.

– Make small balls from the entire mixture. This much of the dough will make at least 15 koftas.

– Drop slowly in hot oil and deep fry. Take out and drain. You can relish these meatballs as is or as filling in pita bread or wrap in tortillas. You may serve them with hummus as well.

To make a gravy

– Grind 2 onions, 3 fat garlic cloves, half inch ginger, and 4-5 almonds together.

– Put a saucepan over a medium flame. Add 3-4 tbs of oil and heat.

– Add the above paste and fry for 6-7 mins.

– Add 1 tomato, chopped finely.

– Add 1tsp cumin powder , 2tsp coriander powder, 1 tsp turmeric powder, 2 tsp red chilli powder & 1 tsp garam masala.Add salt and about quarter cup of water. Keep stirring the masala another 5-7 min or till the oil separates.

– Add 1 cup of water and lower the flame. Let it simmer for 7-8 min. When the gravy starts to thicken turn off the heat and add the koftas.

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